

A FINITELY PRESENTED GROUP THAT IS NOT MF

ANONYMOUS

ABSTRACT. A countable discrete group is MF if it admits unitary matrix models that are asymptotically multiplicative in operator norm and separate every nontrivial element from the identity; equivalently, if it embeds in the unitary group of a quotient $\prod_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) / \bigoplus_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})$. We construct an explicit finitely presented group E that is not MF, refuting the conjecture that every countable group is MF. The reduced group C^* -algebra of E is a separable, stably finite C^* -algebra that is not MF.

The mechanism is a rigidity theorem for property-(T) subgroups: if $t\Gamma t^{-1} \subseteq \Gamma$, then in operator-norm matrix models conjugation by t preserves the Hilbert–Schmidt asymptotic commutant of Γ . In E this forces a commutator u to converge to 1 in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm. On the other hand, an explicit Clifford-group quotient makes the central involution $w = u^2$ equal to -1 . Together the two facts force every matrix model of E to send w to 1. The construction runs from any finitely presented property-(T) group with a proper injective self-embedding; E is the instance built on $\mathbb{Z}^3 \rtimes \mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$. The obstruction is general: every matrix model maps each finite normal or normal property-(T) subgroup of the compression defect to the identity, one-sided compression collapses commuting involution orbits, and the MF radical of the ambient group is the full preimage of the MF radical of the quotient by the collapse defect.

The homomorphism proving $w \neq 1$ maps E onto a second group W , a Clifford extension of a linear group. We prove that W is finitely generated, sofic, and not MF. Since sofic groups are hyperlinear, neither soficity nor hyperlinearity implies the MF property. The reduced group C^* -algebra of W is in addition exact.

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1 INTRODUCTION

Can every countable discrete group be realized by matrices, if multiplication is only required to hold up to operator-norm errors that vanish along a sequence of finite dimensions? Shulman calls the positive assertion the *MF conjecture* [Sh], and no group was known to fail it [Sc, Sh]. We prove that the answer is no: there is an explicit finitely presented group, on eight generators and forty-one relators, that is not MF. Residually finite groups satisfy the conjecture through their finite quotients, as do LEF groups [CDE] and, by quasidiagonality [TWW], all amenable groups. Recent work establishes it for many amalgamated free products [Sc, Sh, GKEMP]. The corresponding C^* -algebra question is older. Blackadar and Kirchberg, who introduced MF algebras, remarked that no stably finite separable C^* -algebra was known not to be MF [BK, CDE]. Their natural candidate was $C_{\text{red}}^*(F_2)$, which Haagerup and Thorbjørnsen later proved to be MF [HT]. The negative solution of the Connes embedding problem subsequently supplied abstract stably finite non-MF algebras [JNVWY, FGH]. No countable group was known whose reduced or maximal group C^* -algebra fails to be MF [Sh].

These questions sit at the endpoint of a program of finitary approximation. In his 2018 ICM address, Thom asked for which Schatten p -norms there exist non-approximable groups [Th, Question 3.11]. The case $p = 2$ was settled by De Chiffre–Glebsky–Lubotzky–Thom [DGLT], the cases $1 < p < \infty$ by Lubotzky–Oppenheim [LuO], and the case $p = 1$ by Bachner–Dogon–Lubotzky [BDL]. That left the Hamming metric (soficity), the Hilbert–Schmidt norm (hyperlinearity), and the operator norm (MF). The Hamming case was disproved in 2026: the first nonsolic group was constructed by OpenAI [OAI], Fournier-Facio then gave a torsion-free example [FFF], and Kun–Thom developed further wreath-product examples [KT26]. One-sided conjugation of a property-(T) subgroup into itself, the mechanism driving those arguments, is also the starting point of the present one. Soficity concerns permutations in the Hamming metric, and MF concerns unitaries in operator norm, so the operator-norm setting requires a different rigidity argument. We obtain it from a one-sided transport theorem for the Kazhdan fixed spaces of the adjoint actions; Appendix B gives a quantitative finite-stage version. This paper settles the operator-norm case by one explicit finitely presented group; it also proves that soficity does not imply MF and

produces an explicit reduced group C^* -algebra that is stably finite but not MF. Of the three problems, only hyperlinearity remains open.

In the language of approximate representations, a countable discrete group G is *MF* if, for every finite subset $F \subseteq G$ and every $\varepsilon > 0$, there is a unitary matrix model $V: G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(r)$ that is multiplicative within ε in operator norm on F and separates distinct elements of F by operator-norm distance at least 1. There is an equivalent corona formulation, the one in which the notion was introduced by Carrión–Dadarlat–Eckhardt and is used by Shulman and Bachner–Dogon–Lubotzky [CDE, Sh, BDL]. Let $(d_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ be a strictly increasing sequence of positive integers and let

$$(1) \quad \mathcal{Q} = \prod_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) / \bigoplus_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})$$

be the associated matrix quotient: bounded sequences of matrices modulo sequences converging to 0 in operator norm. We call any such corona algebra a *norm matrix corona*. Following Blackadar–Kirchberg [BK], a separable C^* -algebra is *MF* if it embeds into some algebra of the form (1); the group G is MF if there is an injective homomorphism

$$G \longrightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}).$$

The two formulations are equivalent (Proposition 1.1). We shall use the equivalent coordinate model

$$(2) \quad \mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n)) := \prod_n \mathcal{U}(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})) / \{(u_n) : \|u_n - 1\| \longrightarrow 0\}.$$

The denominator is normal, and polar correction gives a canonical isomorphism

$$(3) \quad \kappa_{(d_n)}: \mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n)) \xrightarrow{\cong} \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}),$$

proved in Lemma 2.2. Thus one may equivalently embed G into $\mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$.

Proposition 1.1 (equivalent MF formulations). *For every countable group, the C^* -corona definition above is equivalent to the unitary-sequence definition. The latter is equivalent to operator-norm local models with separation constant 1, and allowing arbitrary positive dimensions is equivalent to requiring the dimensions to be strictly increasing.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWriters.manuscriptMFDefinitionEquivalences]

The proof is deferred, together with the precise formulation of the operator-norm local models, to Appendix A. Its three ingredients are an explicit tensor-power amplification in one direction, the weak-MF-to-corona implication in the other, and a cumulative-block dimension normalization.

Hereafter “MF” means this property: the operator-norm notion of Carrión–Dadarlat–Eckhardt, in the form used by Shulman, with no additional requirement that matrix models recover the regular representation, its norms, or its trace. Stronger conventions exist. In [GKEMP] the approximating maps must also recover the canonical trace and the left-regular norm on every group-ring element. The purely matricial field (PMF) convention of [MdlS,

Definition 1.2] requires finite-dimensional representations whose group-ring norms converge to the regular norms.

Throughout, $[g, h] = ghg^{-1}h^{-1}$ for group elements, while for matrices $[x, y] = xy - yx$; the arguments always make the reading unambiguous.

The result and the mechanism Theorem A produces an explicit group E on eight generators $v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z, t, c$ with forty-one relators, containing a designated central involution w , such that $w \neq 1$ and yet every homomorphism from E to the unitary group of a norm matrix corona sends w to 1. In particular no such homomorphism is injective, and E is not MF. The proof has four steps, each of which admits a quantitative form at a fixed matrix dimension (Appendix B).

- (1) An operator-norm approximate representation acts by conjugation on the Hilbert–Schmidt space of each matrix block, and operator-norm control keeps this adjoint action approximately multiplicative.
- (2) The subgroup of E generated by the images of v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z is a quotient of a group $\mathcal{B}$ with property (T), proved intrinsically from the displayed presentation. At each dimension, property (T) provides a finite-stage Kazhdan projection, whose range is the spectral subspace of vectors almost fixed by the adjoint action of that subgroup.
- (3) The defining relations give $t\iota(\mathcal{B})t^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\mathcal{B})$. This yields a one-sided containment between the almost-fixed subspace and its conjugate by t . The two projections have equal rank, and the equal-rank reversal estimate upgrades the containment to equality: conjugation by t preserves the Hilbert–Schmidt asymptotic commutant of the base. Equivalently, in the ultraproduct proof, the fixed-space projection satisfies $P \leq VPV^*$, and finiteness of the ambient C^* -ultraproduct — no proper isometries — forces equality.
- (4) The element c commutes with the base image, so its conjugate $d = tct^{-1}$ asymptotically commutes with it as well. Hence the commutator $u = [d, v_1]$ converges to 1 in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm. If some model detected the central involution $w = u^2$, cutting to the corner of $q = (1 - \Theta(w))/2$ would give a model in which $w = -1$ exactly, at normalized Hilbert–Schmidt distance 2 from 1. But $w \neq 1$ in E : an explicit Clifford-group quotient makes d and $v_1dv_1^{-1}$ anticommuting involutions and w the central sign.

rigidity: $u \sim_2 1$	versus	Clifford model: $w = u^2 = -1$.
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The sign is the smallest instance of the mechanism, not its extent. Section 9 proves the general forms: any finite normal subgroup of the defect obstructs corona representations through a Reynolds corner (Theorem 9.2); the intrinsic defect generated by all one-sided conjugators and centralizers enters the MF radical (Theorem 9.4); normal property-(T) subgroups of the defect obstruct through the moving spectral subspace, with no finiteness or torsion (Theorem 9.5); and the datum itself can be discarded in favor of its one output,

Hilbert–Schmidt invisibility (Theorem 9.6). In the formal development the dependencies run in exactly that direction: the sign criterion is the two-element case of the finite-normal criterion, and the finite-normal criterion is the finite case of the normal-Kazhdan obstruction. Section 11.2 then turns the obstruction into a computation: one-sided compression collapses entire conjugation orbits of involutions, the MF radical is the full preimage of the radical of the quotient by the collapse defect, and a group whose collapse defect saturates admits no nontrivial homomorphism to any countable MF group at all.

Two groups play distinct roles. The finitely presented group E is the main example: it is not MF, and we do not determine whether E itself is sofic or hyperlinear (Section 12). The homomorphism proving $w \neq 1$ maps E onto a second, finitely generated group W , a Clifford extension of a linear group, and Theorem E proves that W is sofic — hence hyperlinear — and not MF. Soficity is established for W , not for E . On the algebra side, the reduced group C^* -algebra of E is the stably finite non-MF example (Theorem D); the reduced algebra of W is in addition exact.

Operator norm versus tracial approximation The argument is specific to operator norm: the transport theorem requires the adjoint actions to be controlled in operator norm on the Hilbert–Schmidt spaces. Hilbert–Schmidt-small defects alone do not provide that control, so the proof does not give a hyperlinear obstruction.

Inputs and formal verification The proof of Theorem A is self-contained. Property (T) of the base is proved from three ingredients: an exact rational spectral certificate, an explicit surjection verified relator by relator, and a fixed-point bridge (Proposition 6.2). The Clifford witness and the finite-dimensional obstruction are proved directly. The classical identification of the base with $\mathbb{Z}^3 \rtimes \mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$ (Remark 6.3) is not used. Later sections quote literature results only where indicated: quasidiagonality of amenable groups [TWW] in Section 10, the Elek–Szabó extension theorem [ES06] and Mal’cev residual finiteness [Mal] as context in Theorem E, and the simple sofic embedding theorem [ES05] in the simple-envelope paragraph.

Each gray Lean tag names a theorem in the accompanying Lean 4 development whose statement matches the displayed claim under the conventions of this paper; the formal development has no theorem-level inputs. The formal development follows the finite-stage transport proof of Appendix B. The body proof of Theorem 3.1 is the equivalent ultraproduct argument. The paragraphs quoting the literature results above are outside the formal development and are labelled where they occur. In the public version each tag links to the corresponding declaration on the reviewed source branch.

Relation to prior work The closest conceptual analogue is the recent work on nonsofic groups. One-sided conjugation of a property-(T) subgroup and propagation from its centralizer appear in [OAI, KT26], building on rigidity

results of Kun and Kun–Thom [Ku16, KT19]. Related centralizer rigidity for sofic embeddings is proved in [AT]. Those results concern Hamming or tracial approximations. Here the adjoint actions stay on the Hilbert–Schmidt spaces of the matrix blocks, and finiteness prevents a one-sided compression of the Kazhdan fixed space from being proper. In quantitative form this is the equal-rank reversal estimate for explicit finite-stage spectral subspaces (Appendix B). The complementary finite-group corner then converts that rigidity into a fixed nontrivial element sent to the identity by every corona representation. The Clifford central extension supplies the element whose survival is proved independently. No theorem in this paper uses [OAI, KT26] as an input.

Slofstra’s constructions supply close precedents for the Clifford group, distinguished central involution, shift, and HNN doubling map [Slo18, Section 2 and Remark 3.3]. Negative-eigenspace compression appears in Slofstra–Vidick [SV, proof of Proposition 2.7], and Bachner–Dogon–Lubotzky develop operator-norm rounding, compression, and polar-correction procedures in detail [BDL, Lemmas 2.2–2.3, Proposition 2.4, and the proof of Proposition 1.5]. That local procedure enters the finite-normal corner reduction below. The transport step itself is Theorem 3.1.

The analytic passage from operator norm to the Hilbert–Schmidt conjugation representation belongs to the $\pi \otimes \bar{\pi}$ framework of Bekka and Bekka–Valette [Be, BV]. Dadarlat uses normalized finite-rank projections as almost invariant Hilbert–Schmidt vectors in an operator-norm approximation argument [Dad, Lemma 3.18 and Proposition 3.19]. These are the direct analytic precedents for the conjugation step used here.

Slofstra’s quotients by elements invisible to exact or approximate finite-dimensional representations precede the MF-radical language used below [Slo17, Definitions 2.5–2.7]. Fritz’s marked $\text{BS}(2, 3)$ example provides additional context for the cyclic comparison [Fri, SV].

Central extensions and rigidity of approximate representations also drive the Frobenius obstruction of De Chiffre–Glebsky–Lubotzky–Thom [DGLT]. In the proof of Proposition 1.6, Bachner–Dogon–Lubotzky treat the finite-central case by a character-isotypic corner, and reduce the general finite-normal case to it by passing to the finite-index centralizer [BDL]. The finite-normal criterion here combines the corresponding coordinate-corner construction with the one-sided Kazhdan conjugation and does not assume that the quotient is hyperlinear. Related finite-target approximation and extension results for weak soficity appear in [GR, Gl].

Carrión–Dadarlat–Eckhardt provide the group-MF framework used here. Through Abels’ group, they also provide an amenable MF group that is not residually finite [CDE, Section 2.14 and Corollary 2.18]. The cyclic comparison addresses the narrower question of what happens to the marked conjugation configuration when property (T) is removed.

Finally, failure of the MF property for a group C^* -algebra does not by itself prevent the group from embedding into a corona: the group property

requires only a faithful canonical image in some MF quotient of $C_{\max}^*(E)$. For E , the nontrivial element w lies in the kernel of every corona representation.

Organization Section 2 fixes notation, the corona lifting lemmas, and the conventions. Sections 3 and 4 isolate the analytic mechanism and the general construction, and state Theorem A with its uniform finite corollary and the scaling family. Section 5 states and proves Theorem B, the exact finite-dimensional model of the mechanism. Section 6 constructs E and proves property (T) for its base. Section 7 proves $w \neq 1$. Section 8 proves the defect-square identity and deduces Theorem A from the sign criterion. Section 9 defines Kazhdan conjugation data and their defect subgroups and generalizes the sign criterion four ways: the finite-normal obstruction criterion (Theorem 9.2), the intrinsic defect in the MF radical (Theorem 9.4), the normal-Kazhdan form (Theorem 9.5), which requires no finiteness or torsion, and the abstract invisibility form (Theorem 9.6), which requires no datum at all. Section 10 states and proves the cyclic comparison, Theorem C. Section 11 states and proves Theorems D and E, develops the MF radical, proves the involutive orbit collapse with its radical reduction and saturation endpoints (Section 11.2), and establishes the permanence failures. Section 12 records the limitations of the operator-norm method. Appendix A proves the MF equivalences, Appendix B gives the finite-stage transport proof, and Appendix C records the maximal group C^* -algebra.

2 NOTATION AND CORONA LEMMAS

All groups are discrete and countable. Property (T) is the textbook complex-unitary property. A C^* -homomorphism is unital only when this is stated. In particular, an MF embedding may be nonunital, as is customary for embedding a unital algebra as a C^* -subalgebra. If $e: A \rightarrow B$ is an injective, possibly nonunital $*$ -homomorphism between unital C^* -algebras, then $u \mapsto e(u) + (1 - e(1))$ is an injective homomorphism $\mathcal{U}(A) \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(B)$; this complement correction is used below. For a unital C^* -algebra A we write $\mathcal{U}(A)$ for its unitary group. On $M_r(\mathbb{C})$ we use the normalized trace tr_r , the operator norm $\|\cdot\|$, and the normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm $\|x\|_2 = \text{tr}_r(x^*x)^{1/2}$. For coordinate sequences we write $a \sim_2 b$ when $\|a_n - b_n\|_2 \rightarrow 0$. We will use three elementary facts without further comment: $\|x\|_2 \leq \|x\|$; $|\text{tr}_r(x)| \leq \|x\|$; and $\|uxv\|_2 = \|x\|_2$ for unitaries u, v . For a nonempty finite set Y , write $M_Y(\mathbb{C}) = \mathbb{C}^{Y \times Y}$ for the corresponding indexed matrix algebra.

Given a sequence $(d_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ of positive integers, we write

$$\mathcal{Q}((d_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}) = \prod_{n \in \mathbb{N}}^{\ell^\infty} M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) / \bigoplus_{n \in \mathbb{N}}^{c_0} M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}),$$

the quotient of the bounded C^* -product by the ideal of sequences with $\|x_n\| \rightarrow 0$. We call any such algebra a *norm matrix corona*. We also write

$$\mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}) = \prod_{n \in \mathbb{N}} \mathcal{U}(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})) / \{(u_n) : \|u_n - 1\| \rightarrow 0\}.$$

Write $q: \prod_{n \in \mathbb{N}}^{\ell^\infty} M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) \rightarrow \mathcal{Q}$ for the quotient map of a norm matrix corona.

The following lifting facts are standard perturbation theory; see Loring [Lo] for a systematic treatment.

Lemma 2.1 (lifting). *Every unitary $u \in \mathcal{Q}$ lifts to a sequence of unitaries.*

[Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptUnitaryLifting]

Proof. Lift u to an arbitrary bounded sequence (x_n) . Since $q((x_n))$ is unitary, the one-sided Gram defect satisfies $\|x_n^* x_n - 1\| \rightarrow 0$; no condition on $x_n x_n^*$ is needed. Once $\|x_n^* x_n - 1\| \leq \frac{1}{2}$, the square Gram matrix $x_n^* x_n$ is invertible, hence so is x_n , and the polar correction $u_n = x_n (x_n^* x_n)^{-1/2}$ is unitary. Continuous functional calculus gives the quantitative estimate

$$\|u_n - x_n\| \leq 2 \|x_n\| \|x_n^* x_n - 1\|.$$

The sequence (x_n) is bounded, so the right-hand side tends to 0. Setting $u_n = 1$ at the finitely many remaining indices therefore gives a unitary sequence with $\|u_n - x_n\| \rightarrow 0$. $\square$

Lemma 2.2 (unitaries in the quotient). *For every sequence (d_n) , the map*

$$\kappa_{(d_n)}: \mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n)) \longrightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q}), \quad [(u_n)] \longmapsto q((u_n)),$$

is a canonical group isomorphism. [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptUnitaryCoronaEquivalence]

Proof. The map is well defined, and its kernel consists exactly of the unitary sequences satisfying $\|u_n - 1\| \rightarrow 0$, so it is injective. It is surjective by Lemma 2.1: every unitary in $\mathcal{Q}$ has a unitary lift (u_n) , whose class in (2) maps to it. $\square$

A *corona representation* of a group H is a homomorphism $H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$, and it *detects* $g \in H$ — separates g from the identity — when it does not send g to 1. An *operator-norm asymptotic representation* of H is a sequence of maps $U_n: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d_n)$ such that $\|U_n(g)U_n(h) - U_n(gh)\| \rightarrow 0$ for all $g, h \in H$. Lemma 2.2 canonically identifies a corona representation with a homomorphism into $\mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$, which we call its coordinate model. A countable group is *MF* if it admits an injective corona representation for a strictly increasing dimension sequence; by the dimension-amplification equivalence, allowing an arbitrary positive dimension sequence gives the same class of groups. Taking $g = h = 1$ gives $\|U_n(1) - 1\| \rightarrow 0$ automatically, since $U_n(1)$ is unitary. Coordinate unitary lifts of a corona representation of a countable group form exactly such a sequence.

The maximal group C^* -algebra $C_{\text{max}}^*(H)$ is used only for the final assertions of Theorem A. Appendix C records its construction and universal property.

3 ONE-SIDED KAZHDAN TRANSPORT

The proof rests on one principle, which appears in three finite settings:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} X \subseteq Y, |X| = |Y| & V \subseteq W, \dim V = \dim W & \begin{array}{c} p \leq q, p \sim q \\ \text{in a finite } C^*\text{-algebra} \end{array} \\ \Downarrow & \Downarrow & \Downarrow \\ X = Y & V = W & p = q. \end{array}$$

In the right-hand column, $p \sim q$ is Murray–von Neumann equivalence and *finite* is meant in the C^* -sense: no proper isometries. The middle implication is used exactly in Theorem B: the commutant of the base is carried into itself by conjugation, and equal finite dimension forces equality. For matrix models, the right-hand implication gives the proof printed below: property (T) supplies a Kazhdan projection P in a norm ultraproduct, the one-sided conjugation gives $P \leq VPV^*$, and finiteness forces equality. The same argument runs quantitatively at each single coordinate, with an almost-fixed spectral subspace in place of the Kazhdan projection and the equal-rank reversal estimate in place of finiteness. That finite-stage proof, which the formalization uses, is given in Appendix B. This yields the reusable theorem behind every result below.

Recall from Section 2 the notions of corona representation, detection, and operator-norm asymptotic representation, and the notation $a_n \sim_2 b_n$ for $\|a_n - b_n\|_2 \rightarrow 0$ in the normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm.

Theorem 3.1 (Kazhdan transport of Hilbert–Schmidt asymptotic commutants). *Let Γ and H be groups, let Γ have property (T), let $\iota: \Gamma \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism, let $s \in H$, and let (d_n) be a sequence of positive integers. Suppose*

$$s\iota(\Gamma)s^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\Gamma).$$

Let $U_n: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(d_n)$ be an operator-norm asymptotic representation. If (x_n) is uniformly operator-norm bounded and asymptotically centralizes $\iota(\Gamma)$ in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm,

$$\|x_n U_n(\iota(\gamma)) - U_n(\iota(\gamma)) x_n\|_2 \rightarrow 0 \quad (\gamma \in \Gamma),$$

then the conjugated sequence does as well:

$$\|[U_n(s)x_n U_n(s)^*, U_n(\iota(\gamma))]\|_2 \rightarrow 0 \quad (\gamma \in \Gamma).$$

[Lean: GroupApproximation.KazhdanAsymptoticCommutant.manuscriptKazhdanTransport]

Proof. Suppose the conclusion fails: there are $\gamma_0 \in \Gamma$, $\delta > 0$, and an infinite set $I \subseteq \mathbb{N}$ with $\|[U_n(s)x_n U_n(s)^*, U_n(\iota(\gamma_0))]\|_2 \geq \delta$ for $n \in I$. Fix a free ultrafilter ω on $\mathbb{N}$ with $I \in \omega$.

The adjoint model. Regard $M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})$ as the Hilbert space $K_n = L^2(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}), \text{tr}_{d_n})$ and let each group element act on it by conjugation, $\text{Ad } U_n(g) \xi = U_n(g) \xi U_n(g)^*$. Operator-norm almost multiplicativity of U_n makes $g \mapsto \text{Ad } U_n(g)$ an operator-norm asymptotic representation on these Hilbert spaces; this conjugation maneuver is the finite-stage form of the $\pi \otimes \bar{\pi}$ construction.

The ultraproduct. Let K_ω be the Hilbert-space ultraproduct of the K_n along ω and let $B_\omega = \prod_\omega B(K_n)$ be the norm ultraproduct, acting on K_ω ; write $[\cdot]_\omega$ for classes in either. Asymptotic multiplicativity makes

$$\pi: H \longrightarrow \mathcal{U}(B_\omega), \quad \pi(g) = [\text{Ad } U_n(g)]_\omega,$$

a homomorphism. The algebra B_ω is *finite*. Indeed, suppose $\sigma = [\sigma_n]_\omega$ satisfies $\sigma^* \sigma = 1$. Then $\|\sigma_n^* \sigma_n - 1\| \rightarrow 0$ along ω , and each σ_n acts on a finite-dimensional space. Polar correction therefore replaces σ_n by a unitary w_n with $\|\sigma_n - w_n\| \rightarrow 0$. Hence $\sigma = [w_n]_\omega$ is unitary.

The Kazhdan projection. Property (T) provides a finite symmetric generating set $S \subseteq \Gamma$ with $1 \in S$ and a Kazhdan constant $\kappa \in (0, 1]$ for the pair (S, κ) . Let h be the Hermitian part of $\frac{1}{|S|} \sum_{s' \in S} \pi(\iota(s'))$ and let $\text{Fix} \subseteq K_\omega$ be the subspace of vectors fixed by every $\pi(\iota(\gamma))$. Both Fix and its orthocomplement are invariant under each unitary $\pi(\iota(s'))$, hence under h . On Fix , $h = 1$. The restriction of $\pi \circ \iota$ to $\text{Fix}^\perp$ has no nonzero invariant vector, so a unit vector $\xi \in \text{Fix}^\perp$ satisfies $\|\pi(\iota(s'))\xi - \xi\| \geq \kappa$ for some generator. For that generator $\text{Re}\langle \pi(\iota(s'))\xi, \xi \rangle \leq 1 - \kappa^2/2$, while every other term is at most 1. Averaging gives $\langle h\xi, \xi \rangle \leq 1 - \kappa^2/(2|S|)$. Consequently

$$\text{sp}(h) \subseteq \left[-1, 1 - \frac{\kappa^2}{2|S|}\right] \cup \{1\},$$

and the spectral projection P of h at the isolated point 1 belongs to B_ω by continuous functional calculus and projects onto Fix .

One-sided compression and finiteness. Let $V = \pi(s)$ and $Q = VPV^*$. Since $s\iota(\Gamma)s^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\Gamma)$, every vector of Fix is fixed by each $\pi(s\iota(\gamma)s^{-1})$. On the other hand, η is fixed by all $\pi(s\iota(\gamma)s^{-1})$ exactly when $V^*\eta \in \text{Fix}$. Hence

$$\text{ran } P = \text{Fix} \subseteq V \text{Fix} = \text{ran } Q, \quad \text{that is,} \quad P \leq Q.$$

The element $r = V^*Q$ satisfies $r^*r = Q$ and $rr^* = V^*QV = P$. Since $r^*r = Q$, we have $r = rQ$. Since $\text{ran } r = \text{ran } P \subseteq \text{ran } Q$, we also have $r = Qr$. Hence the cross terms in $\sigma^*\sigma$ vanish for $\sigma = r + (1 - Q)$, and $\sigma^*\sigma = Q + (1 - Q) = 1$: σ is an isometry. Finiteness of B_ω makes σ unitary, and $\sigma\sigma^* = P + (1 - Q)$ forces

$$Q = P.$$

Conclusion. Let $\xi = [\xi_n]_\omega \in K_\omega$, where $\xi_n \in K_n$ is the vector of x_n ; the uniform operator-norm bound makes ξ well defined. By unitary invariance of the normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm, the commutator hypothesis says exactly that each $\pi(\iota(\gamma))$ fixes ξ . Thus $\xi \in \text{Fix}$. Since $Q = P$, we obtain

$$V\xi \in V \text{Fix} = \text{ran } Q = \text{ran } P = \text{Fix}.$$

The vector of $U_n(s)x_nU_n(s)^*$ is $\text{Ad } U_n(s)\xi_n$, so, again by unitary invariance,

$$\|[U_n(s)x_nU_n(s)^*, U_n(\iota(\gamma))]\|_2 = \|(\text{Ad } U_n(\iota(\gamma)) - 1) \text{Ad } U_n(s)\xi_n\| \rightarrow 0$$

along ω , for every $\gamma \in \Gamma$. Taking $\gamma = \gamma_0$ contradicts $I \in \omega$. Since the failing subsequence was arbitrary, the full sequence converges. $\square$

Remark 3.2 (the finite-stage proof). The proof above is not quantitative: the ultrafilter hides the rate. Appendix B proves the theorem a second time, quantitatively at each single coordinate n , with no ultrafilter or subsequence. There, an explicit almost-fixed spectral subspace of the averaged adjoint action replaces the Kazhdan projection, and the equal-rank reversal estimate replaces finiteness of B_ω . That proof yields an explicit rate in terms of κ , $|S|$, the uniform bound on (x_n) , and the multiplicative defects of U_n , and the formalization uses it.

The entire non-MF argument is the following consequence of the transport theorem, applied to the two-element central subgroup $\{1, \varepsilon\}$. Its proof cuts a corona representation to the corner where the sign ε is -1 ; Section 9 generalizes the same cut from the sign subgroup to an arbitrary finite normal subgroup.

Theorem 3.3 (central-sign criterion). *Let H and Γ be countable groups, let Γ have property (T), let $\iota : \Gamma \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism, and suppose*

$$t\iota(\Gamma)t^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\Gamma), \quad [c, \iota(\Gamma)] = 1.$$

Put $d = tct^{-1}$ and $u = [d, \iota(a)]$ for some $a \in \Gamma$. If

$$\varepsilon = u^2 \neq 1, \quad \varepsilon^2 = 1, \quad \varepsilon \in Z(H),$$

then every homomorphism from H to a norm matrix corona maps ε to the identity, and H is not MF. [Lean: GroupApproximation.KazhdanCompressionCore.manuscriptCentralSignCriterion]

Proof. Suppose some corona representation $\Theta : H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$ satisfies $\Theta(\varepsilon) \neq 1$; we derive a contradiction. Choose coordinate unitary lifts $(V_{g,n})$ of Θ (Lemma 2.1); they form an operator-norm asymptotic representation of H .

The negative corner. Form the coordinate averages $p_n = \frac{1}{2}(1 + V_{\varepsilon,n})$. Because the lifts are asymptotically multiplicative and ε is a central involution, (p_n) is asymptotically self-adjoint and idempotent, and asymptotically central for all of $\Theta(H)$. Spectral rounding at $1/2$ of the Hermitian part of p_n produces genuine coordinate projections; let q_n be their complements — the corners where the sign is negative. If $q_n = 0$ for all large n , the averages converge to 1 and $\Theta(\varepsilon) = 1$, contrary to assumption. Retain an infinite set of coordinates with $q_n \neq 0$ and relabel them by $\mathbb{N}$. Compress every lift to the corner $q_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) q_n \cong M_{r_n}(\mathbb{C})$ with $r_n = \text{rank } q_n > 0$, and polar-correct the compressed matrices. The result is an operator-norm asymptotic representation $(W_{g,n})$ of H on nonzero blocks, each block carrying its own normalized trace, with

$$\|W_{\varepsilon,n} + 1\| \longrightarrow 0 :$$

since $p_n = \frac{1}{2}(1 + V_{\varepsilon,n})$ and the rounded average vanishes on its complementary corner, the compressed sign is asymptotically -1 in operator norm.

Transport on the corner. The corner lifts $(W_{c,n})$ are unitary, hence uniformly bounded, and the relation $[c, \iota(\Gamma)] = 1$ makes them asymptotically centralize the corner lifts of $\iota(\Gamma)$. Theorem 3.1, applied on the corner blocks

with $s = t$, places the corner lifts of $d = tct^{-1}$ in the same Hilbert–Schmidt asymptotic commutant. Hence $\|W_{u,n} - 1\|_2 \rightarrow 0$ for the defect $u = [d, \iota(a)]$, and asymptotic multiplicativity gives $\|W_{\varepsilon,n} - 1\|_2 \rightarrow 0$ for $\varepsilon = u^2$.

The contradiction. At every retained coordinate,

$$2 = \|2 \cdot 1\|_2 \leq \|1 - W_{\varepsilon,n}\|_2 + \|W_{\varepsilon,n} + 1\|_2 \leq \|W_{\varepsilon,n} - 1\|_2 + \|W_{\varepsilon,n} + 1\|_2 \rightarrow 0,$$

which is absurd. Hence every corona representation maps ε to the identity; since $\varepsilon \neq 1$, none is injective, and H is not MF. $\square$

4 THE KAZHDAN–CLIFFORD CONSTRUCTION

Given Γ, α, a as in the theorem below, the construction admits a conceptual presentation with one redundant generator ε : declare it to be a central involution and impose

$$(4) \quad \boxed{\varepsilon = u^2, \quad u = [tct^{-1}, a].}$$

This is the conceptual presentation: rigidity forces $u \sim_2 1$, whereas the Clifford model makes $u^2 = -1$. The theorem below uses the Tietze-eliminated version. Since $d = tct^{-1}$ is an involution, $u^2 = [d, ada^{-1}]$; conversely, centrality of u^2 forces $(u^2)^2 = 1$. Thus the redundant sign costs one generator and puts the defining relation in the boxed form above.

Theorem 4.1 (Kazhdan–Clifford construction). *Let Γ be a finitely presented group with property (T), let $\alpha: \Gamma \hookrightarrow \Gamma$ be an injective endomorphism, and choose $a \in \Gamma \setminus \alpha(\Gamma)$. Adjoin elements t, c and impose*

$$t\gamma t^{-1} = \alpha(\gamma), \quad c^2 = 1, \quad [c, \gamma] = 1 \quad (\gamma \in \Gamma).$$

Put

$$d = tct^{-1}, \quad u = [d, a], \quad w = u^2 = [d, ada^{-1}],$$

and impose centrality of w . More explicitly, for a finite generating set S_Γ it is enough to impose the conjugation and commutation relations for $s \in S_\Gamma$, together with

$$[w, s] = 1 \quad (s \in S_\Gamma), \quad [w, t] = [w, c] = 1.$$

Thus w commutes with a generating set of the entire resulting group. The group $E(\Gamma, \alpha, a)$ is finitely presented, the canonical map $\Gamma \rightarrow E(\Gamma, \alpha, a)$ is injective, and w is a nontrivial central involution. Every homomorphism

$$E(\Gamma, \alpha, a) \longrightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$$

to the unitary group of every norm matrix corona maps w to 1. Consequently $E(\Gamma, \alpha, a)$ is not MF. [Lean: GroupApproximation.KazhdanCliffordConstruction.kazhdanCliffordConstruction]

Proof. Finite presentability follows from a relative finite presentation: start with the free product of Γ and the free group on t, c , and quotient by the finitely many displayed relations for a finite generating set of Γ .

The relation $w^2 = 1$ is redundant. Put $b = ada^{-1}$. Both d and b are involutions, $w = [d, b] = (db)^2$, and direct cancellation gives

$$(5) \quad dwd^{-1} = w^{-1}.$$

Centrality also gives $dwd^{-1} = w$, whence $w = w^{-1}$ and $w^2 = 1$.

For nontriviality, realize the ascending HNN extension

$$G = \langle \Gamma, t \mid t\gamma t^{-1} = \alpha(\gamma) \rangle$$

as a mapping telescope. Let Γ_∞ be the direct limit of the system $\Gamma \xrightarrow{\alpha} \Gamma \xrightarrow{\alpha} \cdots$; injectivity of α passes to the limit, so the level-zero map embeds Γ in Γ_∞ . Applying α levelwise induces an injective endomorphism σ of Γ_∞ . It is surjective, hence an automorphism, because an element at level k equals σ of the same element at level $k+1$. Put $G = \Gamma_\infty \rtimes_\sigma \mathbb{Z}$, with stable letter t implementing σ ; then $t\gamma t^{-1} = \alpha(\gamma)$ for $\gamma \in \Gamma$. Write $X = G/\Gamma$ for the coset space of the level-zero copy. Let G permute the Clifford generators $(e_x)_{x \in X}$ and map c to e_Γ . Then

$$d \mapsto e_{t\Gamma}, \quad ada^{-1} \mapsto e_{at\Gamma}.$$

The two cosets are distinct: equality would give $t^{-1}at \in \Gamma$, equivalently $a \in \alpha(\Gamma)$. Hence the two Clifford generators anticommute and

$$w \mapsto (e_{t\Gamma}e_{at\Gamma})^2 = -1.$$

The Clifford sign is central, so the map respects every defining relation. It follows simultaneously that $w \neq 1$ and that the canonical map of Γ is injective.

Finally, $w = u^2$ is a nontrivial central involution. The central-sign criterion therefore says that every corona representation maps w to the identity. Since $w \neq 1$, none is faithful. $\square$

The sign argument has a useful generalization. For a subgroup $L \leq H$, let $G_{\text{comp}}(L)$ be generated by the elements s satisfying $sLs^{-1} \subseteq L$ — the *one-sided conjugators* of L — and put

$$(6) \quad \mathfrak{D}(H, L) = \left\langle\left\langle [gzg^{-1}, \ell] : g \in G_{\text{comp}}(L), z \in C_H(L), \ell \in L \right\rangle\right\rangle_H.$$

Theorem 9.4 in Section 9 upgrades the sign criterion to this intrinsic defect: in the presence of a property-(T) subgroup $L = \iota(\Gamma)$, every finite normal subgroup of H contained in $\mathfrak{D}(H, L)$ is mapped to the identity by every corona representation of H .

The element a enters both halves of the proof. Analytically, $a \in \Gamma$, so fixed-space transport forces the displaced lamp to commute with its image in finite-dimensional norm models. Geometrically, $a \notin \alpha(\Gamma)$, so a moves that lamp to a different HNN coset, where Clifford anticommutation produces -1 .

Remark 4.2 (a small-cancellation realization). Fournier-Facio has pointed out (personal communication, 2026) that the affine base of Sections 6–8 can be replaced by a small-cancellation construction as in [FFF]. His finitely

presented torsion-free property-(T) group P contains a copy of every finitely presented torsion-free group, in particular a direct product $P_1 \times P_2$ with $P_i \cong P$. Then $\alpha: P \xrightarrow{\cong} P_1 \leq P$, together with any $a \in P_2 \setminus \{1\}$, satisfies the hypotheses of Theorem 4.1. This realization is not formalized, and $E(P, \alpha, a)$ contains involutions whatever the base. The affine base is used for the explicit presentation of Theorem A and for Theorems D and E.

The following theorem is the explicit instance, developed in Sections 6–8. **Theorem A** (explicit Kazhdan–Clifford group). *Let E be the group on the eight generators $v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z, t, c$ with the forty-one relators displayed in Definition 6.1. Put*

$$w = [tct^{-1}, v_1(tct^{-1})v_1^{-1}].$$

The defining relations make w central; together with $c^2 = 1$, centrality implies $w^2 = 1$. Then:

- (1) $w \neq 1$ in E , so w is a central involution;
- (2) for every sequence (d_n) of positive integers and every group homomorphism $\Theta: E \rightarrow \text{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$ into the corresponding unitary norm corona (2), one has $\Theta(w) = 1$.

In particular E is not MF, and neither $C_{\text{max}}^(E)$ nor $C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ is an MF C^* -algebra.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralNonMFEndpoint.manuscriptTheoremA]

Theorem A has an equivalent uniform local-model form:

Corollary 4.3 (uniform finite operator-norm obstruction). *There are a number $\delta > 0$ and a finite set $F_0 \subset E$ such that, in every matrix dimension, any unitary-valued map ϕ satisfying*

$$\|\phi(gh) - \phi(g)\phi(h)\| \leq \delta \quad (g, h \in F_0)$$

also satisfies $\|\phi(w) - 1\| < 1$. [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralUniformObstruction.literal_uniform_operatorNorm_obstruction]

Proof. Suppose no such pair (δ, F_0) existed. For each n , choose a model violating the conclusion for $\delta = 1/n$ and the n th set of an exhaustion of E . These models form an operator-norm asymptotic representation of E whose values at w stay at distance at least 1 from the identity. Its class in the unitary-sequence corona is a corona representation detecting w , contradicting Theorem A(2). The compactness argument is not quantitative; determining an effective modulus from the rational spectral certificate of Section 6 remains open. $\square$

The same construction works for every exponent. For $m \geq 2$, let E_m be the same eight-generator presentation, replacing the three relations $tv_it^{-1} = v_i^2$ by $tv_it^{-1} = v_i^m$ and leaving every other relator unchanged; thus $E_2 = E$. Write w_m for the image of the same marked word w .

Corollary 4.4 (the scaling family). *For every natural number $m \geq 2$, the group E_m is finitely presented and w_m is a nontrivial central involution mapped to the identity by every homomorphism from E_m to every unitary norm matrix corona. Consequently E_m is not MF, and neither $C_{\text{max}}^*(E_m)$*

nor $C_{\text{red}}^*(E_m)$ is an MF C^* -algebra. [Lean: GroupApproximation.ScalingFamilyEndpoint.manuscriptTheoremFamily]

Proof. Replace the affine dilation $\text{diag}(2, 2, 2, 1)$ by $\text{diag}(m, m, m, 1)$ (both acting as in Lemma 7.2). It conjugates each integral translation v_i to v_i^m and fixes the three linear generators. Its inverse sends v_1 to translation by e_1/m , which is not integral; hence the two Clifford sites remain distinct and w_m maps to -1 . The Kazhdan base, the one-sided conjugation argument, and the central-sign criterion are independent of m . $\square$

For the proof of Theorem A, put $d = tct^{-1}$ and $u = [d, v_1]$. Lemma 8.1 gives the identity $w = u^2$. For a corona representation that detects w , the negative corner of w gives a model in which $w = -1$ exactly. Kazhdan transport gives $u \sim_2 1$, hence $w = u^2 \sim_2 1$. This contradiction is the proof of the sign criterion, run at the marked word of E . Section 8 deduces the theorem from the sign criterion and the witness, and Section 9 generalizes the criterion to arbitrary finite normal subgroups of the defect. [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralNonMFEndpoint.negativeCorner_kazhdanTransport_contradiction]

Nontriviality of w is witnessed by an explicit representation of E into a semidirect product of a Clifford group by a mapping-telescope group built from the exact rational affine matrix model (Section 7).

Generalizations and consequences Theorem A is an instance of a general finite-normal obstruction (Definition 9.1). A Kazhdan conjugation datum consists of a property (T) group Λ , a homomorphism $\iota: \Lambda \rightarrow H$, and elements $t, c \in H$ such that $t\iota(\Lambda)t^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\Lambda)$ and $[c, \iota(\Lambda)] = 1$. Every corona representation is trivial on each finite normal subgroup contained in the resulting defect subgroup (Theorem 9.2). For E , the relevant subgroup is $\{1, w\}$. Corollary 11.6 records the resulting obstruction for C^* -subalgebras of norm matrix coronas, while Theorem C shows that finite-dimensional collapse by itself does not decide whether the marked word is trivial. The group E yields a finite universal Horn sentence valid in every MF group and falsified by E , hence a nonempty clopen set of non-MF marked groups (Proposition 11.12 and Corollary 11.13). It also yields the failures of quotient and extension permanence (Corollary 11.17 and Section 11).

5 THE FINITE-DIMENSIONAL OBSTRUCTION

The finite-dimensional argument uses only finite dimensionality and the one-sided conjugation and centralizer relations — neither property (T), nor unitarity, nor centrality of w — and it kills the entire intrinsic defect (6):

Theorem B (the exact finite-dimensional analogue). *Let k be a field, V a finite-dimensional k -vector space, H a group, $\Gamma \leq H$ a subgroup, and $t, c \in H$, $a \in \Gamma$ elements with $t\Gamma t^{-1} \subseteq \Gamma$ and $c\gamma = \gamma c$ for all $\gamma \in \Gamma$. Then every homomorphism $\pi: H \rightarrow \text{GL}(V)$ satisfies*

$$\pi([tct^{-1}, a(tct^{-1})a^{-1}]) = 1.$$

More generally, every such π sends the entire subgroup $\mathfrak{D}(H, \Gamma)$ to the identity.

[Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptTheoremB]

Applied to $H = E$, Theorem B shows that *every* finite-dimensional representation of E over *every* field sends w to the identity. Consequently finite-dimensional linear representations do not separate the points of E , no finite quotient can witness $w \neq 1$, and the infinite Clifford witness of Section 7 cannot be replaced by a finite-dimensional one. In the terminology of [BDL, Definition 1.2], the central involution w , invisible in every finite quotient, makes E a group of *Deligne type*. Such groups were proposed there as the natural candidate counterexamples for all three remaining approximation problems, and E realizes that proposal at the operator-norm endpoint. Property (T) enters the corona argument through the Kazhdan fixed-space projection of the adjoint actions — in quantitative form, a finite-stage spectral subspace at each coordinate, where the equal-rank reversal estimate of Appendix B plays the role that equal dimension plays in the exact argument below.

Proof of Theorem B. Let $\pi: H \rightarrow \mathrm{GL}(V)$ be a homomorphism and let

$$C = \{x \in \mathrm{End}_k(V) : \pi(\gamma)x = x\pi(\gamma) \text{ for all } \gamma \in \Gamma\}$$

be the commutant of $\pi(\Gamma)$, a linear subspace of $\mathrm{End}_k(V)$. Let $u = \pi(t)$ and consider the linear automorphism $\Phi(x) = uxu^{-1}$ of $\mathrm{End}_k(V)$.

We claim $C \subseteq \Phi(C)$. Let $x \in C$ and set $y = u^{-1}xu$, so that $x = \Phi(y)$. For $\gamma \in \Gamma$ we have $t\gamma t^{-1} \in \Gamma$, hence $\pi(t\gamma t^{-1})$ commutes with x , and therefore

$$\pi(\gamma)y = u^{-1}\pi(t\gamma t^{-1})xu = u^{-1}x\pi(t\gamma t^{-1})u = y\pi(\gamma).$$

Thus $y \in C$, proving the claim. Since Φ is a linear isomorphism, $\dim_k \Phi(C) = \dim_k C < \infty$, and the inclusion $C \subseteq \Phi(C)$ forces

$$(7) \quad C = \Phi(C) = uCu^{-1}.$$

Now $\pi(c) \in C$ because c centralizes Γ . By (7), $\pi(tct^{-1}) = u\pi(c)u^{-1} \in C$. Since $a \in \Gamma$, the element $\pi(tct^{-1})$ commutes with $\pi(a)$, so $\pi(a(tct^{-1})a^{-1}) = \pi(tct^{-1})$, and therefore

$$\pi([tct^{-1}, a(tct^{-1})a^{-1}]) = [\pi(tct^{-1}), \pi(tct^{-1})] = 1. \quad \square$$

The same calculation proves the final, subgroup-valued assertion of Theorem B. The elements of H whose conjugation action preserves C in both directions form a subgroup. The argument above puts every one-sided conjugator in that subgroup, and therefore puts all of $G_{\mathrm{comp}}(\Gamma)$ in it. Thus, for $g \in G_{\mathrm{comp}}(\Gamma)$ and $z \in C_H(\Gamma)$, the operator $\pi(gzg^{-1})$ still belongs to C and commutes with every $\pi(\ell)$, $\ell \in \Gamma$. Hence π kills all the generators in (6), and normality of its kernel kills their normal closure.

Corollary 5.1. *The group E of Definition 6.1 admits no injective homomorphism into $\mathrm{GL}(V)$ for any finite-dimensional vector space V over any field. More strongly, every finite-dimensional linear representation maps w to the identity, and every homomorphism to a finite group maps w to the*

identity. [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralFiniteDimensionalObstruction.manuscriptFiniteDimensionalConsequences]

Proof. Apply Theorem B with $H = E$, the image of $\mathcal{B}$, and the elements t, c, v_1 ; the hypotheses hold by the defining relations (10). Every finite-dimensional representation kills w , and $w \neq 1$ by Proposition 7.3. For a finite target, compose with its faithful left regular representation on the group algebra over $\mathbb{Q}$. The composite is a finite-dimensional linear representation, so it kills w . Evaluating the resulting identity matrix at the basis vector of the identity element returns the image of w in the finite group. $\square$

Remark 5.2 (the invariant-size principle). The proof of Theorem B consumed exactly one feature of finite dimensionality: a subspace of a finite-dimensional space that contains an isomorphic copy of itself equals it. The formal development isolates the abstract form. Suppose a conjugation-invariant size σ with values in $\mathbb{N}$ is defined on the subgroups of a group Q and satisfies the separation property that $K \leq L$ with $\sigma(L) \leq \sigma(K)$ forces $K = L$. If $gKg^{-1} \subseteq K$, then gKg^{-1} and K have equal size, so the inclusion is an equality: such a target admits no strict one-sided compression. [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptInvariantSizePrinciple] Cardinality on the subgroups of a finite group and the dimension of the fixed space of the adjoint action in a finite-dimensional representation both qualify: finite quotients and finite-dimensional linear representations are blind to strict one-sided compression for one and the same reason. The corona argument of Theorem A is the analytic residue of this principle at infinite dimension. Why the corona argument is different. The proof of Theorem B used only that a finite-dimensional subspace cannot be properly contained in an isomorphic image of itself. An MF model is only asymptotically multiplicative, so its coordinate fixed spaces are not literal invariant subspaces. Operator-norm control keeps the coordinate adjoint actions almost multiplicative on the Hilbert–Schmidt spaces. Property (T) then supplies an almost-fixed spectral subspace. The equal-rank reversal estimate of Appendix B turns its one-sided compression into equality. These are the quantitative counterparts of the exact finite-dimensional steps above.

6 THE EXPLICIT PRESENTATION AND ITS PROPERTY-(T) BASE

We work throughout with the groups defined by the relators below. Classically the base is the affine group $\mathbb{Z}^3 \rtimes \mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$, a familiar Kazhdan group (Remark 6.3); the reader should keep that model in mind. The proof of property (T) given here is nevertheless intrinsic to the displayed presentations and independent of the identification. It has three ingredients: an exact rational spectral certificate for an auxiliary Steinberg-type presentation, an explicit surjection onto the linear presentation, and a fixed-point bridge from

the linear subgroup to the full base. First define the *linear presentation*

$$(8) \quad \mathcal{R} = \left\langle x, y, z \mid \begin{array}{l} x^3 = y^3 = z^2 = (xz)^3 = (yz)^3 = 1, \\ (x^{-1}zxy)^2 = (y^{-1}zyx)^2 = (xy)^6 = 1 \end{array} \right\rangle,$$

and the *base*

$$(9) \quad \mathcal{B} = \left\langle v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z \mid \begin{array}{l} \text{the eight relations in (8),} \\ [v_1, v_2] = [v_1, v_3] = [v_2, v_3] = 1, \\ xv_1x^{-1} = v_3, \quad xv_2x^{-1} = v_1, \quad xv_3x^{-1} = v_2, \\ yv_1y^{-1} = v_1, \quad yv_2y^{-1} = v_2^{-1}v_3, \quad yv_3y^{-1} = v_1v_2^{-1}, \\ zv_1z^{-1} = v_2v_3^{-1}, \quad zv_2z^{-1} = v_1v_3^{-1}, \quad zv_3z^{-1} = v_3^{-1} \end{array} \right\rangle.$$

Write $\iota: \mathcal{B} \rightarrow E$ for the homomorphism induced by the first six generators of the presentation below. This map is not assumed to be injective.

Definition 6.1. Use the six base generators and the relations displayed in (9). Define

$$(10) \quad E = \left\langle v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z, t, c \mid \begin{array}{l} \text{all relations in (9),} \\ tv_it^{-1} = v_i^2 \quad (1 \leq i \leq 3), \\ txt^{-1} = x, \quad tyt^{-1} = y, \quad tzt^{-1} = z, \\ c^2 = 1, \\ [c, g] = 1 \quad (g \in \{v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z\}), \\ [w, g] = 1 \quad (g \in \{v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z, t, c\}) \end{array} \right\rangle,$$

where w abbreviates the word $[tct^{-1}, v_1(tct^{-1})v_1^{-1}]$. This is an explicit finite presentation with eight generators and forty-one relators: the twenty base relators, six stable-letter relators, c^2 , the six relations making c commute with the base generators, and eight centrality relators. Its defining relations make w central, and centrality together with $c^2 = 1$ implies $w^2 = 1$ by (5). The relations on the six base generators also give

$$t\iota(\mathcal{B})t^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\mathcal{B}), \quad [c, \iota(\mathcal{B})] = 1.$$

[Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralNonMFPresentation.manuscriptLiteralPresentation]

Six generators suffice. The group E is generated by the six elements v_1, x, y, z, t, c . [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralSixGenerator.literal_sixGenerated_finitelyPresented_nonMF] There is also a Tietze-equivalent presentation on these six generators with thirty-two relators. In (10), eliminate v_3 and v_2 by the Tietze substitutions

$$v_3 = xv_1x^{-1}, \quad v_2 = x^2v_1x^{-2}.$$

Delete the two relations used as definitions. After substitution, the remaining x -action relation follows from $x^3 = 1$. The two stable-letter relations for v_2, v_3 follow from the one for v_1 and $[t, x] = 1$; the two c -commutation relations and two centrality relations for v_2, v_3 similarly follow from those for v_1 and

x . These six redundant relators may therefore be deleted. Starting from forty-one relators, the two Tietze definitions, the remaining x -action relation, and those six consequences leave thirty-two, on the generators v_1, x, y, z, t, c .

Figure 1 isolates the geometry used later in the analytic argument. The element $d = tct^{-1}$ centralizes the compressed copy, not necessarily all of $\iota(\mathcal{B})$. The marked commutator measures precisely that failure after conjugating d by $\iota(v_1)$.

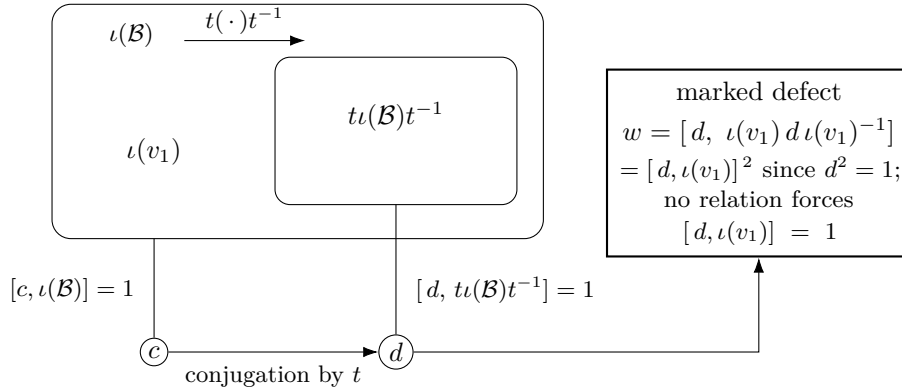


Figure 1: The one-sided conjugation configuration. Conjugation by t carries the image of the base into itself. It sends c to $d = tct^{-1}$: the relations force c to commute with all of $\iota(\mathcal{B})$ and force d to commute with the compressed copy, but do not require d to commute with $\iota(v_1)$. The marked word w records that commutation defect. Only the one-sided inclusion is used by the analytic criterion.

In particular the conjugation argument needs only the one-sided inclusion and centralizer relations shown in Figure 1; it never uses injectivity or properness of the base map. Injectivity for the constructed group is established independently by the Clifford realization.

6.1 Property (T) of the base

Proposition 6.2. *The twenty-relator group $\mathcal{B}$ has property (T), in both the real-orthogonal and complex-unitary formulations.*

[Lean: GroupApproximation.L
iteralBaseP13PropertyTBridge.manuscriptBaseHasKazhdanPropertyT]

Proof. The proof has three steps.

Step 1: a certified Steinberg-type presentation. Let P_{13} be the group on the six generators $e_{12}, e_{13}, e_{21}, e_{23}, e_{31}, e_{32}$ with the thirteen relators

$$\begin{aligned} [e_{12}, e_{23}] &= e_{13}, & [e_{13}, e_{32}] &= e_{12}, & [e_{21}, e_{13}] &= e_{23}, \\ [e_{23}, e_{31}] &= e_{21}, & [e_{31}, e_{12}] &= e_{32}, & [e_{32}, e_{21}] &= e_{31}, \\ [e_{12}, e_{13}] &= [e_{12}, e_{32}] = [e_{13}, e_{23}] = [e_{21}, e_{23}] = [e_{21}, e_{31}] = [e_{31}, e_{32}] = 1, \\ (e_{12} e_{21}^{-1} e_{12})^4 &= 1, \end{aligned}$$

the elementary-matrix relations in rank three. An exact sum-of-squares certificate with integer matrix data, verified by denominator-free rational arithmetic, proves the degree-one Hodge estimate for P_{13} with spectral gap $\frac{1}{500}$. Testing it on coboundaries gives, in every orthogonal representation, the quadratic gap

$$\|\Delta\xi\|^2 \geq \frac{1}{500} \langle \Delta\xi, \xi \rangle$$

for the six-generator Laplacian Δ . The gap places the spectrum of Δ in $\{0\} \cup [\frac{1}{500}, \infty)$. The kernel of Δ is exactly the space of invariant vectors. Hence a unit vector almost fixed by the six generators has small Laplacian energy and is close to an invariant vector. This yields a Kazhdan pair: P_{13} has property (T). Certificates of this kind go back to Ozawa's algebraic characterization of property (T) [Oz] and its computer-assisted implementations for $\mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$ [NT].

Step 2: the explicit surjection onto the linear presentation. Map the six generators to the words

$$\begin{aligned} e_{12} &\mapsto y^{-1}xyz^{-1}x^{-1}, & e_{13} &\mapsto xzy^{-1}x^{-1}y, & e_{21} &\mapsto y^{-1}xyxz, \\ e_{23} &\mapsto x^{-1}y^{-1}xzy^{-1}, & e_{31} &\mapsto xy^{-1}xzy^{-1}x, & e_{32} &\mapsto x^{-1}zy^{-1}x^{-1}y^{-1}x^{-1} \end{aligned}$$

in the linear presentation $\mathcal{R}$ of (8). A word-by-word verification inside $\mathcal{R}$, using only its eight displayed relators, checks that all thirteen relators of P_{13} map to the identity, so the assignment defines a homomorphism $P_{13} \rightarrow \mathcal{R}$. The same computation exhibits explicit words in the six images whose values are z and xy . A further computation shows that z and xy generate $\mathcal{R}$. Hence the homomorphism is surjective. Property (T) passes to quotients, so $\mathcal{R}$ has property (T).

Step 3: the fixed-point bridge to the base. The generators x, y, z of $\mathcal{B}$ satisfy the relators of $\mathcal{R}$, so $\mathcal{R}$ maps to the linear subgroup of $\mathcal{B}$ they generate, and Step 2 gives a finite set S of words in x, y, z and a $\kappa > 0$ forming a Kazhdan pair for it. Let ρ be an orthogonal representation of $\mathcal{B}$ with a unit vector ξ displaced by less than $\kappa/64$ by every element of the finite control set consisting of S together with the translations v_2, v_3 . Three estimates produce an invariant vector near ξ .

- (1) Projecting ξ to the subspace of vectors fixed by the linear subgroup gives such a fixed vector p with $\|p - \xi\| < 1/64$, by the moving-projection estimate for the Kazhdan pair.
- (2) Translations move p by a bound independent of the lattice vector. Three explicit words in x, y, z act on the translation lattice as elementary

transvections. Consequently every lattice element is a product of two linear-subgroup conjugates of basis translations — a two-conjugate normal form proved inside the presentation. A conjugate rvr^{-1} with r in the linear subgroup displaces the fixed vector p exactly as much as v does. Each control translation displaces p by less than $3/64$, because its displacement bound at ξ transfers across $\|p - \xi\|$. Hence every translation displaces p by at most $1/8$.

- (3) The orbit of p under the translation subgroup is bounded, so the Hilbert-space circumcenter argument applies: the projection η of p to the translation-fixed subspace satisfies $\|\eta - p\| \leq 1/8$. The linear subgroup normalizes the translation subgroup and fixes p , so η is fixed by it as well. Translations and the linear generators generate $\mathcal{B}$, so η is $\mathcal{B}$ -invariant. Finally, $\|\eta - \xi\| \leq 1/8 + 1/64 < 1$ keeps η nonzero.

Thus almost-invariant vectors produce invariant vectors and $\mathcal{B}$ has property (T) in the real-orthogonal formulation; realification and complexification identify it with the complex-unitary formulation. $\square$

Remark 6.3 (the classical identification). Classically, the eight relations (8) present $\mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$ [CRW, Theorem 2]; the matrix-labelled form of the generators in Lemma 7.2 is also recorded in [CLV]. The base $\mathcal{B}$ is then the affine group $\mathbb{Z}^3 \rtimes \mathrm{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$. Property (T) of that affine group is classical [BHV, Example 1.7.4(i)]. Thus property (T) of $\mathcal{B}$ also follows from the classical results; the proof above is independent of them.

7 THE WITNESS: $w \neq 1$

Clifford signs, shifts, and HNN doubling have appeared together before in approximate-representation theory, notably in Slofstra’s hyperlinear-profile construction [Slo18, Section 2]. The construction below uses the Clifford lamp only as an explicit algebraic witness. It uses the displayed quotient of the base and is independent of the classical identification recorded in Remark 6.3.

Construction 7.1 (Clifford lamp groups). For a set X , use the real Clifford-algebra convention generated by $(c_x)_{x \in X}$ with $c_x^2 = 1$ and $c_x c_y = -c_y c_x$ for $x \neq y$, and let $\mathrm{ClLamp}(X)$ be the subgroup of units generated by -1 and the c_x . Write $\zeta = -1$. In this concrete group,

$$\zeta^2 = c_x^2 = 1, \quad c_x c_y = \zeta c_y c_x \quad (x \neq y).$$

The sign ζ is nontrivial. Thus $\mathrm{ClLamp}(X)$ is a central extension, by the sign ζ , of the elementary abelian 2-group on the sites X : distinct site involutions commute only up to ζ , unlike the commuting lamps of a classical lamplighter. Every permutation of X acts on this group by $c_x \mapsto c_{\sigma(x)}$ and fixes ζ . [Lean:

GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptCliffordConstruction]

Lemma 7.2 (linear model). *For $M \in \mathrm{GL}_3(\mathbb{Q})$ and $u \in \mathbb{Q}^3$, write*

$$A(M, u) = \begin{pmatrix} M & u \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Assign $v_i \mapsto A(I_3, e_i)$ and

$$\begin{aligned} x &\mapsto A\left(\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, 0\right), & y &\mapsto A\left(\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & -1 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, 0\right), \\ z &\mapsto A\left(\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 \\ -1 & -1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}, 0\right). \end{aligned}$$

Let $\bar{\Gamma} \leq \mathrm{GL}_4(\mathbb{Q})$ be the subgroup generated by these six matrices, and put $D = \mathrm{diag}(2, 2, 2, 1)$. Direct matrix computation proves that the six matrices satisfy all twenty relators of $\mathcal{B}$ and that

$$\bar{\alpha}(u) = DuD^{-1}$$

is an injective endomorphism of $\bar{\Gamma}$ which squares the three translation generators and fixes x, y, z . Moreover the matrix assigned to v_1 does not lie in $\mathrm{range}(\bar{\alpha})$. [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptLinearModel]

Proof. The twenty relator checks reduce to sixteen rational identities for each matrix equation. Conjugation by D gives the six stable-letter equations and is injective because it is conjugation by an invertible matrix. Every displayed generator and its explicitly computed inverse has integral entries; equivalently, all six generators lie in $\mathrm{GL}_4(\mathbb{Z})$. Hence $\bar{\Gamma} \leq \mathrm{GL}_4(\mathbb{Z})$. However $D^{-1}\bar{v}_1D$ has entry $1/2$ in position $(1, 4)$, so it is not in $\bar{\Gamma}$. This proves the last assertion. $\square$

Form the direct limit $T = \varinjlim(\bar{\Gamma}, \bar{\alpha})$, the algebraic mapping telescope of $\bar{\alpha}$, extend it by its shift τ , and call the resulting group $V = T \rtimes \mathbb{Z}$. Let $j: \bar{\Gamma} \hookrightarrow V$ be the level-zero map. Put $X = V/j(\bar{\Gamma})$, with root $o = j(\bar{\Gamma})$. The final assertion of Lemma 7.2 is exactly the statement that

$$\tau o \neq j(\bar{v}_1)\tau o.$$

Thus the Clifford generators at these two sites anticommute.

Proposition 7.3. *$w \neq 1$ in E .* [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralNonMFLinearWit
ness.literal_mark_ne_one]

Proof. Form $W := \mathrm{CLamp}(X) \rtimes V$ as in Construction 7.1. Define a map on the generators of (10) by

$$\begin{aligned} g &\mapsto j(\bar{g}) \in V \quad (g \in \{v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z\}), \\ t &\mapsto \tau, \quad c \mapsto c_o. \end{aligned}$$

The exact checks in Lemma 7.2 give the twenty base and six stable-letter relations. The level-zero subgroup fixes o , so c_o commutes with every base generator, and $c_o^2 = 1$. Under this assignment,

$$tct^{-1} \mapsto c_{\tau o}, \quad v_1(tct^{-1})v_1^{-1} \mapsto c_{j(\bar{v}_1)\tau o},$$

and the two sites are distinct by Lemma 7.2, so

$$w \mapsto [c_{\tau o}, c_{j(\bar{v}_1)\tau o}] = -1 = \zeta.$$

Since ζ is central in W , the remaining relations $[w, g] = 1$ for $g \in \{v_1, v_2, v_3, x, y, z, t, c\}$ are also satisfied. Hence the assignment extends to a group homomorphism $E \rightarrow W$ sending w to $\zeta \neq 1$, and therefore $w \neq 1$ in E . $\square$

Scope of the witness. The target uses the infinite group $\text{Cilamp}(X)$ when X is infinite, but each group element involves only finitely many Clifford sites, and the remaining data are rational matrices. The mapping telescope supplies the required group, and the range characterization separates the two sites; no HNN normal-form theorem is needed.

8 THE DEFECT SQUARE AND THE PROOF OF THEOREM A

Lemma 8.1 (the marked word is a defect square). *Let H_1 be a group and $d, a_1 \in H_1$ with $d^2 = 1$. Then*

$$[d, a_1 d a_1^{-1}] = [d, a_1]^2.$$

[Lean: GroupApproximation.commutator_conjugate_eq_commutator_sq_of_sq_eq_one]

Proof. Put $b = a_1 d a_1^{-1}$, so $b^2 = a_1 d^2 a_1^{-1} = 1$; thus $b^{-1} = b$ and $d^{-1} = d$. Then $[d, a_1] = d a_1 d^{-1} a_1^{-1} = d (a_1 d a_1^{-1}) = db$, and

$$[d, a_1]^2 = (db)^2 = db db = d b d^{-1} b^{-1} = [d, b]. \quad \square$$

Proof of Theorem A. Part (1) is Proposition 7.3. For part (2), let $\Theta: E \rightarrow \text{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$ be given and pass to the corona representation $\kappa_{(d_n)} \circ \Theta: E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$ of Lemma 2.2. Apply the central-sign criterion (Theorem 3.3) with $\Gamma = \mathcal{B}$, the canonical homomorphism ι , the elements $t, c \in E$, and $a = v_1$. Its hypotheses are exactly the displayed relators: Proposition 6.2 gives property (T) of $\mathcal{B}$; the six stable-letter relators give $t\iota(\mathcal{B})t^{-1} \subseteq \iota(\mathcal{B})$; and the six c -commutation relators give $[c, \iota(\mathcal{B})] = 1$. No injectivity of ι is required. In E we have $d^2 = (tct^{-1})^2 = tc^2t^{-1} = 1$, so Lemma 8.1 with $a_1 = \iota(v_1)$ identifies the marked word as the square of the conjugation defect $u = [d, \iota(v_1)]$:

$$w = [d, \iota(v_1) d \iota(v_1)^{-1}] = [d, \iota(v_1)]^2 = u^2.$$

Centrality of w is a defining relator; together with $c^2 = 1$ it forces $w^2 = 1$ by (5); and $w \neq 1$ by part (1). The criterion therefore sends w to the identity under every corona representation of E . Since $\kappa_{(d_n)}$ is injective, $\Theta(w) = 1$. This proves part (2).

For the final assertions of Theorem A: an MF embedding of E would be an injective corona representation, which is impossible because every corona representation sends the nontrivial element w to 1. Suppose $C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ were an MF algebra, with an injective, possibly nonunital $*$ -homomorphism $e: C_{\text{red}}^*(E) \rightarrow \mathcal{Q}$. Complement correction gives the injective unitary homomorphism $u \mapsto e(u) + (1 - e(1))$. Composing it with the canonical map $E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(C_{\text{red}}^*(E))$, and then with $\kappa_{(d_n)}^{-1}$, would exhibit an injective corona representation of E , because the map $g \mapsto \lambda_g$ is injective. The canonical map $E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(C_{\text{max}}^*(E))$ is injective as well, because the left regular representation factors through $C_{\text{max}}^*(E)$ and sends u_g to λ_g . Thus an MF embedding of $C_{\text{max}}^*(E)$ would again produce an injective corona representation of E after the same $\kappa_{(d_n)}^{-1}$ conversion. $\square$

The marked radical element. The proof shows more than non-injectivity of each individual Θ : the fixed element w lies in the kernel of *every* corona representation of E , so every corona representation factors through $E/\langle w \rangle$ (note $\langle w \rangle = \{1, w\}$ is central, hence normal). In the language of approximation radicals, w is a nontrivial element of the “MF radical” of E . This terminology is meant in analogy with Slofstra’s earlier quotients G^{fin} and G^{fa} , obtained by killing elements invisible to exact and approximate finite-dimensional representations, respectively [Slo17, Definitions 2.5–2.7]. By Theorem 9.2 the same holds in every countable group with a Kazhdan conjugation datum: every finite normal subgroup of its defect subgroup lies in the MF radical. Section 11 develops the radical systematically; we do not know whether $E/\langle w \rangle$ is MF, i.e. whether the MF radical of E is exactly $\{1, w\}$.

Corner ranks. The coordinate Reynolds corner in the proof of Theorem 9.2 discards zero-rank coordinates and equips each retained corner block with its own normalized trace, so all subsequent Hilbert–Schmidt estimates are relative to that block and independent of the ratio r_n/d_n . This is what makes the operator-norm setting insensitive to small relative ranks, which block the same argument in Hilbert–Schmidt metrics (Section 12).

9 THE FINITE-NORMAL OBSTRUCTION

This section generalizes the central-sign criterion from the two-element sign subgroup to an arbitrary finite normal subgroup of the defect, then removes finiteness altogether. The order of presentation is expository; in the formal development the implications run the other way, from the general statements to the sign. Every proof has the same two halves: transport makes the defect Hilbert–Schmidt invisible, and a corner cut converts that invisibility into an exact operator-norm contradiction — with the negative corner of the sign replaced by the Reynolds corner of the finite subgroup, and in the normal-Kazhdan form by the moving spectral subspace. We first fix the data.

Definition 9.1 (Kazhdan conjugation datum). Let H be a countable group. A *Kazhdan conjugation datum* in H is a tuple (Λ, ι, t, c) , where Λ is a

countable group with property (T), $\iota: \Lambda \rightarrow H$ is a group homomorphism — *not* assumed injective — and $t, c \in H$, subject to

(M1) $t \iota(\lambda) t^{-1} \in \iota(\Lambda)$ for every $\lambda \in \Lambda$;

(M2) $c \iota(\lambda) = \iota(\lambda) c$ for every $\lambda \in \Lambda$.

Write $d := tct^{-1}$. The *defect subgroup* of the datum is the normal closure

$$N_{\text{comp}} = \langle\langle [d, \iota(\lambda)] : \lambda \in \Lambda \rangle\rangle_H \trianglelefteq H.$$

[Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptMarkedKazhdanPattern]

Theorem 9.2 (finite-normal obstruction criterion). *Let H be a countable group with a Kazhdan conjugation datum (Λ, ι, t, c) , and let $F \trianglelefteq H$ be a finite normal subgroup with $F \subseteq N_{\text{comp}}$. Then every corona representation $\Theta: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$ satisfies $\Theta(f) = 1$ for all $f \in F$.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptFiniteNormalObstructionCriterion]

Proof. The argument has two independent halves. The first, which uses the Kazhdan datum, is a vanishing theorem in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm; the second, which uses only finiteness and normality of F , converts that tracial invisibility into an exact operator-norm contradiction on a coordinate corner.

Half one: tracial vanishing of the defect. Let $(U_{g,n})$ be coordinate unitary lifts of any operator-norm almost representation of H (in particular, of a corona representation), and put

$$K_2 = \{g \in H : \|U_{g,n} - 1\|_2 \rightarrow 0\}.$$

Unitary invariance and asymptotic multiplicativity make $K_2 \trianglelefteq H$. Since c centralizes $\iota(\Lambda)$, its lifts belong to the Hilbert–Schmidt asymptotic commutant of $\iota(\Lambda)$. Applying Theorem 3.1 to $x_n = U_{c,n}$ puts the lifts of $d = tct^{-1}$ there as well. Therefore $[d, \iota(\lambda)] \in K_2$ for every $\lambda \in \Lambda$. Hence $N_{\text{comp}} \subseteq K_2$, and so $F \subseteq K_2$: every element of the defect subgroup is Hilbert–Schmidt invisible in *every* operator-norm almost representation of H .

Half two: the coordinate Reynolds corner. Suppose a corona representation Θ is nontrivial on F ; choose coordinate unitary lifts $(V_{g,n})$ of Θ and form the coordinate Reynolds averages

$$p_n = \frac{1}{|F|} \sum_{f \in F} V_{f,n}.$$

Because the lifts are asymptotically multiplicative and F is finite, (p_n) is asymptotically self-adjoint and idempotent, and normality of F makes it asymptotically central for all of $\Theta(H)$. Spectral rounding at $1/2$ of the Hermitian part of p_n produces genuine coordinate projections; let q_n be their complements. Nontriviality of Θ on F forces $q_n \neq 0$ along infinitely many coordinates — otherwise the averages converge to 1 and $\Theta|_F$ is trivial. Retain exactly those coordinates and relabel them by $\mathbb{N}$. Compress every lift to the corner $q_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) q_n \cong M_{r_n}(\mathbb{C})$ with $r_n = \text{rank } q_n > 0$, and polar-correct the compressed matrices. The result is an operator-norm almost representation

$(W_{g,n})$ of H on the nonzero corner blocks. Since the corner is the complement of the rounded average, the finite average vanishes there:

$$(*) \quad \left\| \sum_{f \in F} W_{f,n} \right\| \longrightarrow 0 \quad \text{in operator norm.}$$

The contradiction. Half one applies to the corner almost representation $(W_{g,n})$ itself: every $f \in F$ satisfies $\|W_{f,n} - 1\|_2 \rightarrow 0$. Since F is finite, a diagonal selection of coordinates makes this uniform over F . Passing to stages at which all $|F|$ distances are below $1/(n+1)$ gives

$$\sum_{f \in F} W_{f,n} \longrightarrow |F|1 \quad \text{in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm,}$$

each block carrying its own normalized trace. This contradicts $(*)$, because operator-norm convergence dominates normalized Hilbert–Schmidt convergence. Hence no corona representation is nontrivial on F . $\square$

The Reynolds-corner argument used only one property of N_{comp} : every element is Hilbert–Schmidt invisible in every operator-norm almost representation of H . Any normal subgroup with that tracial-vanishing property therefore obstructs its finite normal subgroups in exactly the same way; Theorem 9.4 exploits this.

Theorem A(2), proved in Section 8 from the sign criterion, is also the instance $H = E$, $\Lambda = \mathcal{B}$, ι the canonical homomorphism, and $F = \{1, w\}$ of Theorem 9.2; the membership $w \in N_{\text{comp}}$ is the identity $w = [d, \iota(v_1)]^2$ of Lemma 8.1.

9.1 The intrinsic defect The transport estimate applies to every one-sided conjugator of a subgroup, not only to the element t . Recall from (6) the subgroup $G_{\text{comp}}(L)$ generated by all one-sided conjugators of a subgroup $L \leq H$ and the intrinsic defect $\mathfrak{D}(H, L)$.

Corollary 9.3 (transport along all one-sided conjugators). *Let (r_n) and $V_{g,n} \in \mathcal{U}(r_n)$ be an operator-norm asymptotic representation of H , let Λ have property (T), let $\iota: \Lambda \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism, and put $L = \iota(\Lambda)$. Suppose that $(x_n \in M_{r_n}(\mathbb{C}))$ is uniformly bounded in operator norm and belongs to the Hilbert–Schmidt asymptotic commutant of L :*

$$\left\| x_n - V_{\iota(\lambda),n} x_n V_{\iota(\lambda),n}^* \right\|_2 \longrightarrow 0 \quad (\lambda \in \Lambda).$$

Then every $g \in G_{\text{comp}}(L)$ acts in both directions on that asymptotic commutant. Explicitly, both

$$V_{g,n} x_n V_{g,n}^* \quad \text{and} \quad V_{g,n}^* x_n V_{g,n}$$

satisfy the preceding convergence for every $\lambda \in \Lambda$. [Lean: GroupApproximation.K
azhdanAsymptoticCommutant.compressionGroup_transport_both]

Proof. For a one-sided conjugator s , Theorem 3.1 gives forward transport. Reverse transport follows from the same proof: the equality $P = VPV^*$ obtained there gives $V^*PV = P$ as well, so the fixed subspace is preserved

by conjugation in both directions. In the finite-stage proof of Appendix B, the equal-rank reversal estimate reverses the one-sided containment of the spectral subspaces; the same argument then runs with the adjoint unitary, with the displacement and concentration steps unchanged. The elements acting in both directions form a subgroup of H , and hence contain the subgroup generated by all one-sided conjugators, namely $G_{\text{comp}}(L)$. $\square$

Theorem 9.4 (the intrinsic defect and the MF radical). *Let H and Γ be countable groups, let Γ have property (T), let $\iota: \Gamma \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism, and put $L = \iota(\Gamma)$. If $F \trianglelefteq H$ is finite and $F \leq \mathfrak{D}(H, L)$, then every homomorphism from H to every norm matrix corona maps every element of F to the identity.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.KazhdanAsymptoticCommutant.manuscript CompressionRadical]

Proof. By the factorization recorded after Theorem 9.2, it suffices to prove the tracial half for the larger subgroup: every element of $\mathfrak{D}(H, L)$ is Hilbert–Schmidt invisible in every operator-norm almost representation of H . So let $(U_{h,n})$ be coordinate lifts of such a representation and put $K_2 = \{h : \|U_{h,n} - 1\|_2 \rightarrow 0\}$, a normal subgroup of H . If $z \in C_H(L)$, then $(U_{z,n})$ lies in the asymptotic commutant. Corollary 9.3 puts $(U_{gzg^{-1},n})$ there for every $g \in G_{\text{comp}}(L)$. Hence each commutator $[gzg^{-1}, \ell]$, $\ell \in L$, belongs to K_2 . Thus every displayed generator of $\mathfrak{D}(H, L)$ belongs to K_2 , and normality of K_2 absorbs the normal closure: $\mathfrak{D}(H, L) \leq K_2$. The coordinate Reynolds corner and the finite-sum contradiction of Theorem 9.2 apply verbatim to any finite normal $F \leq \mathfrak{D}(H, L)$. $\square$

9.2 The normal-Kazhdan form of the obstruction The role of finiteness in Theorem 9.2 is confined to the corner half of the proof. A finite group has property (T), its Reynolds average is precisely its fixed-space average, and the corner of half two is the compression to the subspace on which the F -action is nontrivial. This suggests replacing the Reynolds average by the Kazhdan average of an arbitrary normal property-(T) subgroup. Doing so gives the general form of the obstruction, with no finiteness, centrality, or torsion hypothesis. This form is used in Section 12.

Theorem 9.5 (normal-Kazhdan obstruction). *Let H be a countable group with a Kazhdan conjugation datum (Λ, ι, t, c) , and let $K \trianglelefteq H$ be a normal subgroup with property (T) such that $K \subseteq N_{\text{comp}}$. Then every corona representation $\Theta: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$ satisfies $\Theta(k) = 1$ for all $k \in K$.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptNormalKazhdanObstruction]

Taking $K = F$ finite recovers Theorem 9.2, since finite groups have property (T): the whole group with tolerance 1 is a Kazhdan pair, by orbit averaging. [Lean: GroupApproximation.hasKazhdanPropertyT_of_finite] The two printed proofs differ in which corner they cut, and both are formalized. In Theorem 9.5, K may be infinite, noncentral, and torsion-free.

Proof. The tracial half of Theorem 9.2 needs no finiteness: $N_{\text{comp}} \subseteq K_2$ holds for every operator-norm almost representation of H , so every element of K is Hilbert–Schmidt invisible. What must be replaced is the Reynolds corner, and property (T) of K supplies the replacement.

Suppose a corona representation Θ is nontrivial on K . Its image $\bar{H} = \Theta(H)$ is a countable subgroup of $\mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$, hence MF. Proposition 1.1 therefore provides, for every finite subset of $\bar{H}$ and every tolerance, a matrix model multiplicative within the tolerance that separates distinct elements by *operator-norm* distance at least 1. Choosing models along an exhaustion of $\bar{H}$ gives an operator-norm asymptotic representation $(V_{g,n})$ of $\bar{H}$ in which every fixed nontrivial element eventually stays at operator-norm distance at least 1 from the identity. Operator-norm separation is all such models provide: at growing dimension it places no lower bound on normalized Hilbert–Schmidt distances, and the corner cut below must manufacture the missing tracial separation. The datum and the subgroup pass to their images under Θ : normality and property (T) are preserved, and $\bar{K} = \Theta(K)$, nontrivial by assumption, lies in the defect subgroup of the image datum. So it suffices to derive a contradiction for $\bar{H}$.

The moving spectral subspace. Fix a finite symmetric generating Kazhdan set $S \subseteq \bar{K}$ with constant ε_0 , at each coordinate let h_n be the Hermitian part of the average of the models of S , and cut the spectrum of h_n at $\theta = 1 - \varepsilon_0^2/(4|S|)$. Let q_n be the spectral projection of h_n for $[-1, \theta]$: the *moving spectral subspace*. On its complement — the top spectral subspace — every model of every element of $\bar{K}$ is close to the identity in operator norm, by the Kazhdan-pair displacement estimate. If $q_n = 0$ for all large n , every element of $\bar{K}$ would satisfy $\|V_{k,n} - 1\| \rightarrow 0$, contradicting the operator-norm separation of any fixed nontrivial element of $\bar{K}$. So the moving subspace is nonzero along an infinite set of coordinates, which we retain.

The tracial deficit on the corner. Equip each retained corner block $q_n M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}) q_n$ with its renormalized trace. By the definition of the cut, $q_n h_n q_n \leq \theta q_n$, so the average over S of the real parts of the renormalized traces of the compressed models is at most θ . Hence at every retained coordinate some generator in S has compressed model with real renormalized trace at most θ , and therefore normalized Hilbert–Schmidt distance at least $\sqrt{2(1-\theta)} - o(1)$ from the corner identity after polar correction; passing to a subsequence fixes a single such generator s_0 . The spectral cutoff has converted operator-norm separation into a definite tracial deficit on its own corner.

Compression. Normality makes the cut asymptotically central: conjugation by an ambient model carries the S -average to the average of a conjugate generating set of $\bar{K}$ with the same gap, whose top spectral subspace agrees asymptotically with the original — both consist of the almost- $\bar{K}$ -fixed vectors — so $\|[q_n, V_{g,n}]\| \rightarrow 0$ for every $g \in \bar{H}$. Compressing every model to the moving corner and polar-correcting yields an operator-norm asymptotic

representation of all of $\bar{H}$ on nonzero blocks, in which s_0 keeps a definite normalized Hilbert–Schmidt distance from the identity.

The contradiction. The tracial half applies verbatim to the corner representation: $\bar{K}$ lies in the defect subgroup of the image datum, so every element of $\bar{K}$ — in particular s_0 — is Hilbert–Schmidt invisible on the corner, contradicting the tracial deficit of s_0 . The uniform coordinate scheduling that runs these estimates simultaneously is the stage selection of Theorem 9.2. $\square$

The proofs above consume the conjugation datum through one property only: transport makes the defect subgroup Hilbert–Schmidt invisible in every operator-norm almost representation. Isolating that property decouples the two halves of the mechanism.

Theorem 9.6 (abstract invisibility obstruction). *Let H be a countable group and let $D \leq H$ be a subgroup such that for every operator-norm almost representation of H , the induced homomorphism into the tracial ultraproduct of its blocks, along any ultrafilter refining the cofinite filter, maps every element of D to the identity. Let $K \triangleleft H$ be a normal subgroup with property (T) such that $K \leq D$. Then every corona representation $\Theta: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(\mathcal{Q})$ satisfies $\Theta(k) = 1$ for all $k \in K$.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptAbstractNormalKazhdanObstruction]

Proof. The proof of Theorem 9.5 used its datum only to make every element of the defect subgroup Hilbert–Schmidt invisible in every operator-norm almost representation; here that invisibility is the hypothesis. Suppose a corona representation Θ is nontrivial on K . As there, the image $\bar{H} = \Theta(H)$ is countable and MF, and Proposition 1.1 provides an operator-norm asymptotic representation of $\bar{H}$ that separates every fixed nontrivial element. Every operator-norm almost representation of $\bar{H}$ composes with Θ to one of H , so every element of $\Theta(D)$ inherits the invisibility hypothesis, while $\bar{K} = \Theta(K) \leq \Theta(D)$ is normal, Kazhdan, and nontrivial. The moving spectral subspace, the tracial deficit, and the compression step of the proof of Theorem 9.5 apply verbatim to $\bar{K}$, and the contradiction step uses the inherited invisibility in place of the defect containment. $\square$

Theorem 9.6 separates producing an invisible subgroup from upgrading its corner-rigid pieces to the radical: any source of invisibility — one conjugator, all conjugators, or the orbit collapse of Section 11.2 — feeds the same corner argument. Applied to the intrinsic defect it gives the normal-Kazhdan companion of Theorem 9.4:

Corollary 9.7 (normal-Kazhdan form of the intrinsic radical). *Let H and Γ be countable groups, let Γ have property (T), let $\iota: \Gamma \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism, and put $L = \iota(\Gamma)$. If $K \trianglelefteq H$ is a normal subgroup with property (T) and $K \leq \mathfrak{D}(H, L)$, then every homomorphism from H to every norm matrix corona maps every element of K to the identity.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptIntrinsicNormalKazhdanRadical]

Proof. The proof of Theorem 9.4 shows that every element of $\mathfrak{D}(H, L)$ is Hilbert–Schmidt invisible in every operator-norm almost representation of H : transport places the conjugated centralizers in the asymptotic commutant, the displayed generators in K_2 , and normality of K_2 absorbs the normal closure. Theorem 9.6 with $D = \mathfrak{D}(H, L)$ concludes. $\square$

The subgroup generated by *all* normal property-(T) subgroups of $\mathfrak{D}(H, L)$ therefore also lies in the kernel of every corona representation. [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptIntrinsicNormalKazhdanPart]

10 THE CYCLIC COMPARISON

The finite-dimensional calculation of Section 5 does not by itself determine whether its marked word is trivial:

Theorem C (the cyclic comparison). *Define the marked presentation*

$$E_{\text{BS}} = \left\langle \gamma_0, t, c \left| \begin{array}{l} t\gamma_0 t^{-1} = \gamma_0^2, \quad c^2 = 1, \quad [c, \gamma_0] = 1, \\ w_{\text{BS}}^2 = 1, \quad [w_{\text{BS}}, \gamma_0] = [w_{\text{BS}}, t] = [w_{\text{BS}}, c] = 1 \end{array} \right. \right\rangle,$$

where $w_{\text{BS}} = [tct^{-1}, \gamma_0(tct^{-1})\gamma_0^{-1}]$. Then E_{BS} is finitely presented and $w_{\text{BS}} \neq 1$. There is an explicit surjective homomorphism from E_{BS} onto its realized Clifford quotient that maps w_{BS} to the nontrivial central sign. Nevertheless every finite-dimensional representation of E_{BS} over every field maps w_{BS} to the identity. [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralCyclicCalibration.manuscriptCyclicCalibration]

Thus exact finite-dimensional invisibility does not by itself force triviality of the marked word. The MF conclusion in Theorem A is the separate uniform assertion supplied by the fixed-space argument.

Proof of Theorem C. As with w , the relator $w_{\text{BS}}^2 = 1$ is redundant: tct^{-1} and $\gamma_0(tct^{-1})\gamma_0^{-1}$ are involutions, so centrality forces it by (5). It is retained only to display the marked pattern. Deleting it gives a six-relator presentation of the same group. The stable relation gives $t\langle\gamma_0\rangle t^{-1} \subseteq \langle\gamma_0\rangle$, and c centralizes this cyclic base. The same commutant argument as in Theorem B therefore maps w_{BS} to the identity in every finite-dimensional representation over every field.

For nontriviality, use the affine realization of $\text{BS}(1, 2)$ and its coset action. The root site is fixed by the cyclic base, while the two sites represented by t and $\gamma_0 t$ are distinct. Attach Clifford generators to these sites and map c to the root lamp. All seven relators hold, and

$$w_{\text{BS}} \mapsto [c_{t\langle\gamma_0\rangle}, c_{\gamma_0 t\langle\gamma_0\rangle}] = -1.$$

Thus $w_{\text{BS}} \neq 1$. Restricting the target to the subgroup generated by the three displayed images gives the asserted surjective realized quotient. $\square$

Sharpness of the Kazhdan hypothesis. The realized Clifford quotient in Theorem C is amenable, hence MF, and its quotient map detects w_{BS} . Thus some corona representation of E_{BS} separates the marked word from the identity, and property (T) cannot be omitted from the central-sign criterion. In the radical language of Section 11, $w_{BS} \notin \text{Rad}_{MF}(E_{BS})$. The affine group $BS(1, 2) \cong \mathbb{Z}[1/2] \rtimes \mathbb{Z}$ is solvable. The Clifford lamp group on its coset space is locally finite, so their semidirect product is amenable. The realized quotient is a subgroup of this amenable group and is therefore amenable, hence MF by [TWW]. Its marked word is the nontrivial Clifford sign by the calculation above. The amenable-implies-MF step is a literature input, outside the formal development; the non-LEF statement below is formalized.

This detecting corona representation is necessarily approximate: neither the group E_{BS} nor its realized Clifford quotient is LEF, and the latter is not residually finite. Indeed, in every finite group the doubling relation makes the image of $\langle \gamma_0^2 \rangle$ equal to the image of $\langle \gamma_0 \rangle$; the lamp therefore commutes with the required “halved” element and the marked word collapses. [Lean: GroupApproximation.CyclicBaseLEFObstruction.cyclicBase_exactModel_package]

11 CONSEQUENCES

We record the universal MF radical, the reduced-group- C^* consequence, a sofic non-MF example, and failures of quotient and extension permanence. They all come from the same marked element.

11.1 The MF radical

Definition 11.1. For a countable group G_1 , the *MF radical* is

$$\text{Rad}_{MF}(G_1) = \bigcap \{ \ker \Theta : \Theta \text{ a corona representation of } G_1 \},$$

a normal subgroup of G_1 . This is the operator-norm analogue of the invisible subgroups of [Slo17, Definitions 2.5–2.7] and of the metric-ultraproduct approximation framework of [NST]. [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptMFRadical]

Lemma 11.2 (functoriality). *For every homomorphism $\varphi: G_1 \rightarrow G_2$ of countable groups,*

$$\varphi(\text{Rad}_{MF}(G_1)) \subseteq \text{Rad}_{MF}(G_2) :$$

the MF radical is functorial. In particular, if $\varphi: E \rightarrow G_2$ satisfies $\varphi(w) \neq 1$, then G_2 is not MF. [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptRadicalPortability]

Proof. If $x \in \text{Rad}_{MF}(G_1)$ and Θ is a corona representation of G_2 , then $\Theta \circ \varphi$ is a corona representation of G_1 , so $\Theta(\varphi(x)) = 1$. For the second statement, $w \in \text{Rad}_{MF}(E)$ by Theorem A, so $1 \neq \varphi(w) \in \text{Rad}_{MF}(G_2)$, and an injective corona representation of G_2 would kill $\varphi(w)$, a contradiction. $\square$

Proposition 11.3 (the universal MF quotient). *Let G_1 be a countable group and $R = \text{Rad}_{MF}(G_1)$.*

- (1) R is the kernel of a single corona representation of G_1 .
- (2) G_1/R is MF.
- (3) Every homomorphism from G_1 to an MF group factors through G_1/R .

In particular G_1 is MF if and only if $R = \{1\}$. [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptUniversalMFQuotient]

Proof. (3) If $\varphi: G_1 \rightarrow M$ with M MF and $j: M \rightarrow \mathcal{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$ is an injective corona representation, then $j \circ \varphi$ is a corona representation of G_1 , so $j(\varphi(R)) = 1$ and, by injectivity of j , $\varphi(R) = 1$.

(1) and (2). Work on $Q = G_1/R$ from the outset. If $1 \neq q \in Q$ and $g \in G_1$ represents q , then $g \notin R$. Hence some corona representation of G_1 detects g . Every corona representation kills R by definition, so this representation descends to one of Q that detects q . Thus the intersection of the kernels of all corona representations of the countable group Q is trivial.

Enumerate the nonidentity elements of Q and choose a detecting corona representation for each. Pass to coordinate unitary lifts, so that each detector becomes a sequential almost representation with its marked element separated from 1. Diagonalize at the coordinate level. At stage k , select in each of the first k detectors a coordinate at which multiplicativity holds within $1/k$ on the first k group elements while the marked separation persists. Take the block sum of the k selected matrices. Operator norms of block sums are maxima, so the resulting single sequence is an almost representation detecting every nonidentity element. Its class in the unitary-sequence quotient, composed with the polar-correction isomorphism of Lemma 2.2, is a faithful corona representation of Q . This proves (2). Composing it with $G_1 \twoheadrightarrow Q$ gives a single corona representation of G_1 with kernel exactly R , proving (1). For the final equivalence: if G_1 is MF, an injective corona representation forces $R = \{1\}$; if $R = \{1\}$, then (2) says $G_1 = G_1/R$ is MF. $\square$

Corollary 11.4 (exact radical from a candidate quotient). *Let $N \trianglelefteq G_1$ satisfy $N \leq \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1)$. Every corona representation of G_1 factors uniquely through G_1/N . If in addition G_1/N is MF, then*

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1) = N.$$

[Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptExactRadicalFromCandidateQuotient]

Together with Proposition 11.3, this reduces computing the entire MF radical and the universal MF quotient to two tasks: proving a concrete normal subgroup invisible, and proving its quotient MF.

Proof. The containment $N \leq \ker \Theta$ gives the unique quotient factorization for every corona representation Θ . For the reverse containment in the displayed equality, compose the quotient map $G_1 \rightarrow G_1/N$ with an injective corona representation of G_1/N : its kernel is exactly N , while the MF radical lies in the kernel of every corona representation. $\square$

The MF hypothesis on the quotient can be dropped entirely; what remains is an unconditional reduction.

Corollary 11.5 (radical reduction to the quotient). *Let $N \trianglelefteq G_1$ satisfy $N \leq \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1)$ and let $q: G_1 \rightarrow G_1/N$ be the quotient map. Then*

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1) = q^{-1}(\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1/N)).$$

[Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptRadicalReductionToQuotient]

Proof. For the forward containment, the surjection q carries the radical into the radical by Lemma 11.2. Conversely, suppose $q(x) \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(G_1/N)$ and let Θ be a corona representation of G_1 . Every corona representation of G_1 kills N by hypothesis, so Θ factors as $\bar{\Theta} \circ q$ with $\bar{\Theta}$ a corona representation of G_1/N ; hence $\Theta(x) = \bar{\Theta}(q(x)) = 1$. $\square$

Corollary 11.4 is the case of trivial quotient radical. Corollary 11.5 needs no hypothesis on the quotient: the corona representation theory of G_1 is that of G_1/N , whether or not the latter is MF.

Corollary 11.6. *Let A be a unital C^* -algebra admitting an injective, possibly nonunital, $*$ -homomorphism into a norm matrix corona. Then the group E admits no injective homomorphism into $\mathcal{U}(A)$.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralNonMFConsequences.literal_no_faithful_corona_subalgebra_target]

Proof. Let $j: A \rightarrow Q$ be the possibly nonunital inclusion into the ambient corona and let $\phi: E \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(A)$. Complement correction gives

$$\hat{j}(u) = j(u) + 1 - j(1_A) \in \mathcal{U}(Q).$$

This is an injective homomorphism on $\mathcal{U}(A)$, so $\hat{j} \circ \phi$ is a corona representation of E . By Theorem A(2), $(\hat{j} \circ \phi)(w) = 1$; injectivity of $\hat{j}$ gives $\phi(w) = 1$. Proposition 7.3 has $w \neq 1$, so ϕ cannot be injective. $\square$

11.2 Orbit collapse and defect saturation The criteria of Section 9 bound the radical from below by torsion or rigidity already present in the defect subgroup. One-sided compression also forces identifications: every corona representation identifies an entire conjugation orbit of an involution, so whole families of commutators — not one marked element — enter the radical, and by Corollary 11.5 the radical computation reduces to the quotient by all of them.

Definition 11.7 (involutive compression witness). Let H be a group, $L \leq H$ a subgroup, and $s \in H$. An element $k \in H$ is an *involutive compression witness* for (L, s) if

- (W1) $k^2 = 1$;
- (W2) $s\gamma s^{-1}$ commutes with k for every $\gamma \in L$;
- (W3) the conjugates $\gamma_1 k \gamma_1^{-1}$ and $\gamma_2 k \gamma_2^{-1}$ commute for all $\gamma_1, \gamma_2 \in L$.

The *involutive collapse defect* of the pair (L, s) is the normal subgroup

$$D_{\text{coll}}(L, s) = \langle\langle [\gamma, k] : \gamma \in L, k \text{ an involutive compression witness for } (L, s) \rangle\rangle_H.$$

[Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptInvolutiveCollapsePattern]

In a permutational wreath product $K^{(X)} \rtimes G$ with $L \leq G$ compressed by s and $x_0 \in X$ a point fixed by sLs^{-1} , every involution of the lamp copy at x_0 is a witness: lamps at distinct sites commute, and the compressed copy fixes the site. The theorem below then identifies the lamps along the whole L -orbit of x_0 in every corona representation.

Theorem 11.8 (involutive collapse). *Let H be countable, let $L \leq H$ be a subgroup with property (T), and let $s \in H$ satisfy $s\gamma s^{-1} \in L$ for every $\gamma \in L$. Then*

$$D_{\text{coll}}(L, s) \leq \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H).$$

[Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptInvolutiveCollapse]

Unwinding Definition 11.1: every corona representation Θ of H satisfies $\Theta([\gamma, k]) = 1$ for every witness k and every $\gamma \in L$ — it identifies the entire L -conjugation orbit of each witness with the witness itself. No witness is marked in advance; the defect subgroup collects all of them at once.

Proof. Fix a witness k and suppose some corona representation separates a collapse commutator: coordinate unitary lifts (Lemma 2.2) give an operator-norm almost representation $(U_{g,n})$ of H on blocks $M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C})$ and a $\gamma_0 \in L$ with $\liminf_n \|U_{[\gamma_0, k], n} - 1\| > 0$. We derive a contradiction in six steps.

Step 1: exact commuting involution microstates. For $\gamma \in L$ the elements $v_\gamma = \gamma k \gamma^{-1}$ have asymptotically commuting images that asymptotically square to 1, by (W1), (W3), and asymptotic multiplicativity. Correct them: for a unitary u , the spectral sign of its Hermitian part is an exact self-adjoint involution at operator distance at most $\|u^2 - 1\|$ from u . Block compression along the finite commutative corner structure generated by previously corrected microstates preserves exact commutation. Inductively over an enumeration of L this produces exact, pairwise-commuting, self-adjoint involutions $V_n(\gamma)$ with $\|V_n(\gamma) - U_{v_\gamma, n}\| \rightarrow 0$, covariant in operator norm: $\|U_{g,n} V_n(\gamma) U_{g,n}^* - V_n(g\gamma)\| \rightarrow 0$ for each fixed $g \in L$, where $g\gamma$ abbreviates the orbit index of $gv_\gamma g^{-1}$.

Step 2: the rank displacement metric. For commuting exact involutions u, w the displacement $T = u - w$ is self-adjoint and satisfies $T^3 = 4T$, so $T^2/4$ is an orthogonal projection and

$$\text{Tr } |u - w|^2 = 4 \text{rank}((u - w)^2/4) :$$

unnormalized Frobenius mass and rank are the same invariant on this locus. Set $d_n(\gamma, \mu) = \text{rank}(V_n(\gamma) - V_n(\mu))$, an integer-valued pseudometric. Orthogonal projections at operator distance less than 1 have equal rank, so the covariance of Step 1 makes the displacement eventually translation invariant: $d_n(g\gamma, g\mu) = d_n(\gamma, \mu)$ for all large n , for each fixed triple (g, γ, μ) .

Step 3: generator normalization. Property (T) makes L finitely generated; fix a finite symmetric generating set S forming a Kazhdan pair (S, κ) , and

put $k_n = \sum_{a \in S} d_n(1, a)$. Translation invariance and the triangle inequality for the rank pseudometric give $d_n(1, \gamma) \leq |\gamma|_S k_n$ eventually, where $|\cdot|_S$ is the word length. If $k_n = 0$ along a subsequence, all generator involutions coincide there. By invariance the whole orbit then collapses to a single exact involution, so $\|U_{[\gamma_0, k], n} - 1\| \rightarrow 0$ along that subsequence, against the separation. Hence $k_n \geq 1$ for all large n .

Step 4: the displacement almost-cocycle. Flatten each block to the Euclidean space of matrices and set $b_n(\gamma) = k_n^{-1/2}(V_n(\gamma) - V_n(1))$. By Steps 2 and 3, $\|b_n(\gamma)\|_F^2 \leq 4|\gamma|_S$ at every large stage, while the generators carry total mass exactly

$$\sum_{a \in S} \|b_n(a)\|_F^2 = 4$$

whenever $k_n \geq 1$ — the nonvanishing anchor. Conjugation $x \mapsto U_{g,n} x U_{g,n}^*$ is a Frobenius isometry, and b_n satisfies the cocycle identity $b_n(g\gamma) \approx b_n(g) + U_{g,n} b_n(\gamma) U_{g,n}^*$ up to a defect that is a sum of three covariance errors, each of rank $O(k_n)$ and of vanishing operator norm. Since $\text{Tr } |D|^2 \leq \text{rank}(D) \cdot \|D\|^2$, the defect mass vanishes at the scale k_n . This rank–mass interface keeps every estimate alive after the rescaling: only differences of the involutions are ever measured, never the involutions themselves.

Step 5: bounded profile and an approximate primitive. The limiting profile $\gamma \mapsto \limsup_n \|b_n(\gamma)\|_F^2$ is finite on generators by the anchor. The Gaussian positive-definite functions $e^{-t\|\cdot\|^2}$ of the almost-cocycle are almost invariant under the twisted action, and the spectral gap of the Kazhdan pair (S, κ) bounds the whole profile by its generator values — Delorme’s argument run directly at the level of limiting seminorms. With the profile bounded, a circumcenter of the displacement orbit, taken at the level of bounded sequences, produces one bounded sequence (w_n) that is an approximate primitive: $b_n(a) \approx w_n - U_{a,n} w_n U_{a,n}^*$ in limiting normalized mass, simultaneously for any prescribed finite set of movers.

Step 6: transport through the compressor. By (W2) the compressed copy sLs^{-1} centralizes k , so the corrected microstates are eventually constant along it and the displacement vanishes on compressed elements. Including the compressed generators sas^{-1} among the prescribed movers of Step 5 therefore makes the primitive almost fixed by them. The pulled-back sequence $u_n = U_{s,n}^* w_n U_{s,n}$ is then almost fixed by every generator $a \in S$, because microstates of as^{-1} and $s^{-1}(sas^{-1})$ agree asymptotically. Now transport forward, exactly as in Theorem 3.1: compress u_n to the almost-fixed spectral subspace of the averaged adjoint action of S and apply the one-sided compression $P \leq VPV^*$ at the rescaled mass. The sequence $U_{s,n} u_n U_{s,n}^*$ returns w_n up to vanishing mass and is again almost fixed by every $a \in S$. Hence $b_n(a) \approx w_n - U_{a,n} w_n U_{a,n}^*$ has small mass for every $a \in S$ at a common large stage, contradicting the anchor $\sum_{a \in S} \|b_n(a)\|_F^2 = 4$.

Thus no corona representation separates any collapse commutator, and the kernel of a corona representation, being normal, contains all of $D_{\text{coll}}(L, s)$. $\square$

Remark 11.9 (the formal route). As with the transport theorem, the formal development proves Theorem 11.8 in a fully quantitative single-stage form: the limits above are replaced by explicit tolerances, the circumcenter by an approximate circumcenter of a near-optimal covering sequence, and the final contradiction is assembled from the displayed estimates at one sufficiently late coordinate. The commutation hypothesis (W3) is essential to this proof: it supplies the joint spectral calculus behind the rank identity of Step 2. Anticommuting Clifford coordinates have no joint spectral labels; their collapse mechanism is the central sign of Theorem A. The finite-order analogue for witnesses of order larger than two awaits exact commuting finite-spectrum lifts; the involutive case proved here is the discharged instance.

Corollary 11.10 (collapse computes the radical). *In the setting of Theorem 11.8, write $q: H \rightarrow H/D_{\text{coll}}(L, s)$ for the quotient map. Then, unconditionally,*

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H) = q^{-1}(\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H/D_{\text{coll}}(L, s))),$$

and if $H/D_{\text{coll}}(L, s)$ is MF, then $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H) = D_{\text{coll}}(L, s)$. [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptCollapseRadicalReduction]

Proof. Combine Theorem 11.8 with Corollaries 11.5 and 11.4. $\square$

In the second case $H/D_{\text{coll}}(L, s)$ is the universal MF quotient of H (Proposition 11.3): the corona representation theory of H is computed exactly by the quotient.

Theorem 11.11 (defect saturation). *In the setting of Theorem 11.8:*

- (1) *Every homomorphism f from H to a countable MF group maps every element of $D_{\text{coll}}(L, s)$ to the identity.*
- (2) *If $D_{\text{coll}}(L, s) = H$, then $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H) = H$; every homomorphism from H to a countable MF group is trivial; and if H is nontrivial, then H is not MF.*

[Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptDefectSaturation]

Proof. (1) By Theorem 11.8 and Lemma 11.2, $f(D_{\text{coll}}(L, s)) \leq f(\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(H)) \leq \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(f(H))$; the subgroup $f(H)$ of the MF target is MF (Lemma 11.14), so its radical is trivial by Proposition 11.3. (2) The radical statement is Theorem 11.8 with $D_{\text{coll}}(L, s) = H$; triviality of every homomorphism follows from (1); and a nontrivial group with full radical is not MF by Proposition 11.3. $\square$

A group as in (2) admits no nontrivial finite-dimensional unitary representation, no nontrivial MF quotient, and no nontrivial homomorphism to any countable residually finite or amenable group: an *approximation black hole*. The saturation viewpoint — detect a defect analytically, then saturate it algebraically — develops a suggestion of Fournier-Facio (personal communication, 2026; cf. the Questions preamble of Section 12). Whether a small-cancellation construction produces a finitely presented group with

saturated collapse or normal-Kazhdan defect is open, and the theorems above assume nothing about it.

11.3 A finite universal Horn obstruction Theorem A can be read as one first-order fact about all MF groups at once: a finite quasi-identity, that is, a single universal implication between finitely many equations (a universal Horn sentence). Write R for the forty-one relators of (10), regarded as words in eight variables, and w for the marked word in those variables.

Proposition 11.12 (finite quasi-identity). *Every MF group G satisfies the finite universal Horn sentence*

$$\forall x_1, \dots, x_8: \bigwedge_{r \in R} r(x_1, \dots, x_8) = 1 \implies w(x_1, \dots, x_8) = 1,$$

while the canonical generating tuple of E satisfies every relator in R and has $w \neq 1$. [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralUniversalHorn.manuscriptLiteralUniversalHorn]

Proof. A tuple satisfying the relators induces a homomorphism $E \rightarrow G$ sending the marked word of E to $w(x_1, \dots, x_8)$. If G is MF, that image is trivial: $w \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(E)$ by Theorem A, and the radical is functorial (Lemma 11.2). The canonical tuple of E satisfies R by definition, and its marked word is nontrivial by Theorem A(1). $\square$

Corollary 11.13 (a basic clopen set of non-MF marked groups). *In the space of eight-generator marked groups — quotients of the free group F_8 , topologized so that a basic clopen set fixes the truth of finitely many equations among words in the generators — the marked groups satisfying all relators of R and $w \neq 1$ form a nonempty clopen set consisting entirely of non-MF groups.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralMarkedCylinder.literal_nonempty_clopen_nonMF_cylinder]

Proof. Both conditions constrain finitely many values of the marked multiplication, so the set is clopen; it contains the marked group E by Theorem A(1), and Proposition 11.12 excludes every MF point. $\square$

Thus the obstruction of Theorem A is finite, local, and locally constant on a basic clopen neighborhood in the marked-group topology.

11.4 Permanence and its failure

Lemma 11.14 (subgroups). *Every subgroup of an MF group is MF.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.IsOperatorMF.subgroup]

Proof. Restrict an injective corona representation to the subgroup: injectivity and the homomorphism law are preserved. $\square$

Lemma 11.15 (residually finite groups). *Every countable residually finite group is MF.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.isOperatorMF_of_residuallyFinite]

Proof. Residual finiteness makes the group LEF. For each finite test set F , choose a finite quotient injective on F . Composing with its left regular permutation action gives an *exact* finite local model: every product of elements of F is represented with zero multiplicative defect. Distinct elements of F map to distinct permutations; at a point where the two permutations disagree, the difference of the two permutation matrices has a column of norm at least 1, so the model separates distinct elements of F by operator norm at least 1. These exact permutation models are operator-norm local models with separation constant 1, so the group is MF by the local-to-corona direction of Proposition 1.1. $\square$

Lemma 11.16 (locally finite groups). *Every countable locally finite group is MF.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.isOperatorMF_of_locallyFinite]

Proof. Given a finite test set F , local finiteness supplies one finite subgroup K containing it. Choose any map from the group to K that restricts to the identity on the test set. Applying the left regular permutation action of K to it gives an exact finite local model on F , separating distinct elements by operator norm at least 1 exactly as in Lemma 11.15. Thus the group is LEF, and it is MF by the local-to-corona direction of Proposition 1.1. $\square$

Corollary 11.17 (quotients). *MF groups are not closed under quotients: the free group F_8 is MF, and the explicit group E is its quotient but is not MF.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralMFQuotientControls.manuscriptQuotientNonclosure]

Proof. Map the eight free generators onto the eight displayed generators of E . The resulting homomorphism is surjective because those generators define the displayed presentation. The group F_8 is residually finite, hence MF by Lemma 11.15. Theorem A shows that E is not MF. $\square$

11.5 The reduced group algebra of E Every MF algebra is stably finite [BK], so Theorem D exhibits a separable stably finite C^* -algebra that is not MF. Abstract examples follow from the failure of the Connes embedding problem [FGH]; the point here is concreteness: the algebra is the reduced group C^* -algebra of an explicit finitely presented group. Even for $C_{\text{red}}^*(\text{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z}))$ and $C_{\text{red}}^*(\text{SL}_4(\mathbb{Z}))$ the MF property is undecided; only the stronger PMF property is known to fail, for $\text{SL}_4(\mathbb{Z})$ [MdlS].

Theorem D (the reduced group algebra of E). *$C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ is a unital separable C^* -algebra which carries a faithful tracial state — and is therefore stably finite — but is not an MF algebra.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralNonMFEndpoint.manuscriptTheoremD]

The canonical homomorphism $\mathcal{B} \rightarrow E$ is injective. To see this, compose it with the homomorphism $E \rightarrow W$ of Proposition 7.3; the composite is $g \mapsto j(\bar{g})$, where $\bar{g}$ is the image of g under the surjection $\mathcal{B} \rightarrow \bar{\Gamma}$ of Lemma 7.2. That surjection is an isomorphism by the classical identification of Remark 6.3: the twenty relators present the affine group $\mathbb{Z}^3 \rtimes \text{SL}_3(\mathbb{Z})$, and $\bar{\Gamma}$ is that group in its matrix realization. The level-zero map j is

injective, so the composite is injective. Since the infinite Kazhdan group $\mathcal{B}$ is nonamenable, so is E . Hence $C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ is not nuclear [Lan]. The nuclear form of the Blackadar–Kirchberg problem — whether every stably finite separable nuclear C^* -algebra is quasidiagonal — therefore remains open. This paragraph uses three classical literature inputs, used only here: the presentation identification, nonamenability of infinite Kazhdan groups, and nonnuclearity of the reduced algebra of a nonamenable group.

Lemma 11.18. *Let G_1 be a countable discrete group.*

- (1) *The canonical tracial state τ on $C_{\text{red}}^*(G_1)$ is faithful.*
- (2) *Every unital C^* -algebra A with a faithful tracial state is stably finite: for every nonempty finite index set I , every isometry in $M_I(A)$ is a unitary. In particular this holds in $M_k(A)$ for every $k \geq 1$.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.ManuscriptExactWrappers.manuscriptFaithfulTraceAndStableFiniteness]

Proof. (1) Realize $C_{\text{red}}^*(G_1) \subseteq B(\ell^2 G_1)$ as the norm closure of the span of the left translation unitaries λ_g . Let ρ_g be the right translation unitaries, $(\rho_g \xi)(h) = \xi(hg)$. Each ρ_g commutes with each $\lambda_{g'}$, hence with every element of $C_{\text{red}}^*(G_1)$. The canonical trace is $\tau(x) = \langle x\delta_e, \delta_e \rangle$. If $\tau(x^*x) = 0$ then $\|x\delta_e\| = 0$, so $x\delta_e = 0$, and then $x\delta_g = x\rho_{g^{-1}}\delta_e = \rho_{g^{-1}}x\delta_e = 0$ for every $g \in G_1$. The vectors δ_g are total in $\ell^2 G_1$, so $x = 0$.

(2) On $M_k(A)$ the functional $\tau_k([x_{ij}]) = \frac{1}{k} \sum_i \tau(x_{ii})$ is a state with the trace property $\tau_k(xy) = \frac{1}{k} \sum_{i,j} \tau(x_{ij}y_{ji}) = \tau_k(yx)$, and it is faithful: the i -th diagonal entry of x^*x is $\sum_j x_{ji}^*x_{ji}$, so $\tau_k(x^*x) = 0$ forces $\tau(x_{ji}^*x_{ji}) = 0$, hence $x_{ji} = 0$, for all i, j . If $v \in M_k(A)$ satisfies $v^*v = 1$, then $y := 1 - vv^*$ is a projection with $\tau_k(y) = \tau_k(1) - \tau_k(vv^*) = \tau_k(1) - \tau_k(v^*v) = 0$; since $y = y^*y$, faithfulness gives $y = 0$, i.e. $vv^* = 1$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem D. $C_{\text{red}}^*(E)$ is unital and separable since E is countable; by Lemma 11.18 it carries a faithful tracial state and is stably finite. It is not an MF algebra by Theorem A. $\square$

11.6 A sofic non-MF group The same quotient that proves $w \neq 1$ also provides the sofic non-MF group:

Theorem E (a sofic non-MF group). *The Clifford witness $W = \text{ClLamp}(X) \rtimes V$ of Proposition 7.3 is a finitely generated sofic group that is not MF; since sofic groups are hyperlinear, W is likewise a hyperlinear group that is not MF. In particular, neither soficity nor hyperlinearity implies the MF property.*

[Lean: GroupApproximation.NonMFImpact.witness_sofic_hyperlinear_nonMF]

Proof of Theorem E. Write $T = \varinjlim (\bar{\Gamma}, \bar{\alpha})$, so $V = T \rtimes \mathbb{Z}$, and let $B \leq V$ be the level-zero copy of $\bar{\Gamma}$. The image of $\bar{\alpha}$ has finite index (at most eight, by the parity classes of the translation lattice). Thus every telescope level $\bar{\Gamma}_n \leq T$ is commensurable with B . The stable letter conjugates B onto $\bar{\alpha}(\bar{\Gamma})$, so all of V commensurates B . Orbit–stabilizer now shows that every $\bar{\Gamma}_n$ -orbit in $X = V/B$ is finite.

Consider a finite subset of $\text{ClLamp}(X) \rtimes T$. Its T -coordinates lie in one level $\bar{\Gamma}_n$. Each of its lamp coordinates has finite $\bar{\Gamma}_n$ -orbit: this holds for the central sign and for each site lamp, hence for every Clifford word. The finitely many resulting orbits generate a finite $\bar{\Gamma}_n$ -invariant subgroup $L \leq \text{ClLamp}(X)$, because $\text{ClLamp}(X)$ is locally finite. Our original finite set therefore lies in $L \rtimes \bar{\Gamma}_n$, which is sofic (finite-by-sofic). Soficity is local over finite subsets, so $\text{ClLamp}(X) \rtimes T$ is sofic.

Reassociating the semidirect products gives

$$W = \text{ClLamp}(X) \rtimes (T \rtimes \mathbb{Z}) \cong (\text{ClLamp}(X) \rtimes T) \rtimes \mathbb{Z}.$$

The final group is sofic because a split extension of a sofic group by $\mathbb{Z}$ is sofic. Truncate the integer levels to $\mathbb{Z}/N$ and let the shift act cyclically. Induce the kernel's sofic approximations over this finite level set. The cocycle identity that makes the finite-quotient case exact now fails only on the wrap-around boundary. For a window shifted by k , that boundary occupies at most $2|k|/N$ of the levels, which vanishes as N grows. This is the $\mathbb{Z}$ -extension case of the Elek–Szabó amenable-extension theorem [ES06]. Here $\bar{\Gamma}$ is sofic: its six generators lie in $\text{GL}_4(\mathbb{Z})$, the resulting integral subgroup is residually finite through its congruence quotients, and it is isomorphic to $\bar{\Gamma}$.

The map $E \rightarrow W$ of Proposition 7.3 is surjective: its image contains V , the root lamp c_o , and hence every lamp by transitivity of the V -action on X . Since E is generated by v_1, x, y, z, t, c (by the Tietze calculation above), their six images generate W . The map sends $w \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(E)$ to the nontrivial sign ζ ; functoriality (Lemma 11.2) makes $\zeta \in \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(W)$. Hence W is not MF. $\square$

Failure of extension permanence. MF groups are not closed under extensions. More precisely, W fits into an exact sequence

$$1 \longrightarrow \text{ClLamp}(X) \longrightarrow W \longrightarrow V \longrightarrow 1$$

whose kernel and quotient are MF, while W is not. The concrete lamp kernel is locally finite, LEF, sofic, and MF, while the total witness is finitely generated and non-MF. [Lean: GroupApproximation.LiteralWitnessConsequences.literalWitness_locallyFiniteKernel_nonMF]

Proof. The Clifford lamp group is locally finite, hence MF by Lemma 11.16. The group V identifies with the subgroup of $\text{GL}_4(\mathbb{Q})$ generated by $\bar{\Gamma}$ and D : the telescope levels are $D^{-n}\bar{\Gamma}D^n$, and the determinant records the $\mathbb{Z}$ -coordinate. It is residually finite. At every odd modulus the determinant of the dilation is invertible, so the congruence reduction of the integral affine model descends to conjugation by the dilation and extends over the telescope and its shift. These reductions separate any nontrivial element; compare Mal'cev's theorem [Mal] for finitely generated linear groups. Thus V is MF by Lemma 11.15, whereas W is not MF by the preceding construction. $\square$

An exact stably finite non-MF algebra. The same witness gives a concrete separable exact example: $C_{\text{red}}^*(W)$ is exact, has a faithful tracial state, is stably finite, and is not MF. Indeed, the locally finite lamp kernel is amenable and hence exact, while the linear group $V \leq \text{GL}_4(\mathbb{Q})$ is exact [GHW]. Exact groups are closed under extensions [KW2], so W is exact; for discrete groups this is equivalent to exactness of the reduced group algebra [KW1]. The canonical trace and stable finiteness follow as in Lemma 11.18. Finally, an MF embedding of $C_{\text{red}}^*(W)$ would restrict to a faithful norm-corona model of the canonical group unitaries, contradicting that W is not MF. All parts of this paragraph except exactness are also verified in Lean; the present formal library has no definition of exact C^* -algebras.

A simple sofic envelope. There is a countable simple sofic group S_{simp} with

$$\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(S_{\text{simp}}) = S_{\text{simp}}.$$

Equivalently, every homomorphism from S_{simp} to an MF group is trivial.

Proof. By Elek–Szabó, every countable sofic group embeds in a countable simple sofic group [ES05, Theorem 1]. Embed W in such a group. Functoriality of the MF radical sends ζ to a nontrivial element of the MF radical of the simple group. That radical is normal, so it is the whole group. Every homomorphism to an MF group kills the MF radical. (The embedding theorem is a literature input; this paragraph is outside the formal development.) $\square$

12 LIMITATIONS OF THE OPERATOR-NORM METHOD

The proof is specific to the operator norm. If multiplication is controlled only in normalized Hilbert–Schmidt norm, the induced adjoint operators on the Hilbert–Schmidt spaces need not be close in operator norm. Both transport proofs require exactly that operator-norm control: the ultraproduct proof needs it to obtain an honest representation on the ultraproduct, and the finite-stage proof of Appendix B needs it for the spectral estimates. Normalized Hilbert–Schmidt control therefore does not supply the transport used here.

This is a limitation of the method, not a tracial nonapproximation theorem for E . Alekseev–Thom ask whether commutants arising in sofic approximations of Kazhdan groups can be recovered from finite-dimensional coordinate subalgebras [AT, Open Problem 6.2]. Such a coordinate description is separate from the operator-norm theorem proved here.

Questions The finite-normal criterion has a precise torsion limitation: every finite subgroup of a torsion-free group is trivial. [Lean: GroupApproximation. finiteSubgroup_eq_bot_of_isMulTorsionFree] By Theorem 9.5, a normal property-(T) subgroup of the defect subgroup obstructs corona representations without any torsion. What remains for a torsion-free example is group-theoretic: a torsion-free finitely presented group whose defect subgroup contains a normal subgroup with property (T). Fournier-Facio, who removed the analogous torsion obstacle for nonsocicity [FFF], has suggested (personal communication,

2026; cf. Remark 4.2) that a small-cancellation construction should produce such a group. That suggestion depends on results of Hull and Osin that are cited, not formalized, and is not stated as a theorem here.

- (1) Is $E/\langle w \rangle$ MF? By Corollary 11.4, a positive answer would compute $\text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(E) = \{1, w\}$ exactly. There is a concrete intermediate test. Theorem B sends $u = [tct^{-1}, v_1]$ to the identity in every finite-dimensional representation, whereas the image of u in $W/\langle \zeta \rangle$ is nontrivial: it is the product of the two distinct lamp basis elements at τo and $j(\bar{v}_1)\tau o$. Thus proving $W/\langle \zeta \rangle$ MF would already show $u \notin \text{Rad}_{\text{MF}}(E)$; by Theorem B, no such detecting model can factor through finite quotients or exact finite-dimensional representations.
- (2) Is there a torsion-free finitely presented non-MF group? The analytic obstruction no longer requires torsion (Theorem 9.5); the remaining input is the small-cancellation construction suggested above. By Theorem 11.11, a group whose collapse or normal-Kazhdan defect saturates would admit no nontrivial homomorphism to any countable MF group at all.
- (3) Is E sofic, or hyperlinear? The adjoint spectral estimates require operator-norm multiplicative control, and neither property is decided by the results above.
- (4) Does MF imply hyperlinearity? A faithful embedding into a norm matrix corona need not make any coordinate trace faithful, so the defining MF representation does not immediately supply a hyperlinear model. This question concerns the CDE norm-corona convention fixed above; for stronger trace-controlled MF conventions the implication is built into the definition.

A PROOF OF THE MF EQUIVALENCES

An *operator-norm local model* for a countable group G , a finite set $F \subseteq G$, a separation constant $\delta > 0$, and a tolerance $\varepsilon > 0$ is a map $V : G \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(r)$, for some positive dimension r , such that

$$\begin{aligned} \|V(g)V(h) - V(gh)\| &\leq \varepsilon \quad (g, h \in F), \\ \|V(g) - V(h)\| &\geq \delta \quad (g \neq h \in F). \end{aligned}$$

The local formulation in Proposition 1.1 asks for such a model with $\delta = 1$ for every finite F and every $\varepsilon > 0$.

Proof of Proposition 1.1. Lemma 2.2 identifies the unitary-sequence quotient with the unitary group of the C^* -quotient. Replacing an arbitrary finite coordinate set by a standard set of the same cardinality merely conjugates that coordinate by a permutation unitary. This proves the first equivalence once the dimension convention is normalized.

Suppose first that $\rho : G \rightarrow \text{U}_{\text{cor}}((d_n))$ is injective, and choose unitary lifts $u_n(g)$ of $\rho(g)$. Fix a finite set $F \subseteq G$ and $\varepsilon > 0$. For each ordered pair $g \neq h$ in F , injectivity says that $(u_n(g)^{-1}u_n(h))_n$ does not converge to the identity

in operator norm. Hence there are $\delta_{g,h} > 0$ and arbitrarily large coordinates at which

$$\|u_n(g) - u_n(h)\| \geq \delta_{g,h}.$$

Choose an integer $N_{g,h}$ with $8 < N_{g,h} \delta_{g,h}^2$. An explicit tensor-power estimate then applies: whenever two unitaries are $\delta_{g,h}$ -separated, some tensor power of exponent $p \leq N_{g,h}$ separates them by more than 1 — amplifying a spectral gap of the relative unitary until it crosses the unit circle takes at most $N_{g,h}$ steps once $8 < N_{g,h} \delta_{g,h}^2$. The quotient homomorphism law makes all multiplicative defects for pairs in F arbitrarily small at every sufficiently large coordinate. Choose, for each $g \neq h$, a coordinate with the displayed separation and with every required defect at most $\varepsilon/N_{g,h}$. Then the p th tensor power separates the designated pair by more than 1, while the tensor-product telescoping identity bounds each new defect by $p\varepsilon/N_{g,h} \leq \varepsilon$. Finally take the block sum of these finitely many pair-specific models. Operator norms of block diagonal matrices are maxima, so every pair in F is separated by at least 1 and every required product has defect at most ε . This gives the normalized local model.

Conversely, local models with separation constant 1 for all finite sets and tolerances make the group *weakly* MF. Choose models along an exhaustion with errors tending to zero. Then each fixed pair g, h is eventually represented multiplicatively, and each fixed pair $g \neq h$ is eventually separated by 1. Hence the classes define an injective homomorphism into the unitary-sequence quotient, with no condition on the dimension sequence. Weak MF in turn makes the norm-MF radical of Definition 11.1 trivial, and the block-sum diagonalization in the proof of Proposition 11.3(2) then assembles the detecting sequences into a single faithful corona representation. This weak-to-corona implication is thus obtained from the universal-quotient construction, not from a separate exhaustion.

Finally, we normalize dimensions. Given positive dimensions d_n , replace the n th coordinate model by the cumulative block sum on $X_0 \oplus \cdots \oplus X_n$, where X_k is the k th original model space. Embed the n th original model in the newest block and put identity blocks in all earlier positions. The dimensions $D_n = d_0 + \cdots + d_n$ increase strictly. Products, multiplicative defects, and pairwise operator-norm distances are unchanged, because block-diagonal operator norms are maxima and every earlier block is the same identity for all group elements; in particular no approximation error from earlier coordinates is carried forward. Thus the construction preserves and reflects the quotient relation and injectivity. Forgetting strict increase proves the converse. $\square$

B THE FINITE-STAGE TRANSPORT PROOF

This appendix proves Theorem 3.1 a second time, quantitatively at each single coordinate n ; no ultrafilter or subsequence is needed. This is the route

the formal development follows, and the route referenced by Corollary 9.3 and Section 12.

Finite-stage proof of Theorem 3.1. Property (T) provides a finite symmetric generating set $S \subseteq \Gamma$ with $1 \in S$ and a Kazhdan constant $\kappa \in (0, 1]$ for the pair (S, κ) . The adjoint model is that of the printed proof: each group element acts by conjugation, $\text{Ad } U_n(g) \xi = U_n(g) \xi U_n(g)^*$, on $L^2(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}), \text{tr}_{d_n})$, and operator-norm almost multiplicativity of U_n makes $g \mapsto \text{Ad } U_n(g)$ an operator-norm asymptotic representation on these Hilbert spaces.

The almost-fixed spectral subspace. Let H_n be the Hermitian part of the average $\frac{1}{|S|} \sum_{s' \in S} \text{Ad } U_n(\iota(s'))$, fix the threshold

$$\theta = \frac{1}{2} \left(\left(1 - \frac{\kappa^2}{4|S|} \right) + 1 \right) < 1,$$

and let P_n be the spectral projection of H_n for the part of the spectrum above θ . Two spectral estimates tie P_n to the group.

- (i) *Displacement.* For every $\gamma \in \Gamma$, $\|(\text{Ad } U_n(\iota(\gamma)) - 1) P_n\| \rightarrow 0$. Indeed, a vector whose average S -energy exceeds θ is almost fixed by each generator, because (S, κ) is a Kazhdan pair and θ exceeds $1 - \kappa^2/(4|S|)$. It is then almost fixed by every word in S . The projection P_n is the finite-stage substitute for the Kazhdan projection.
- (ii) *Spectral concentration.* Write $\xi_n \in L^2(M_{d_n}(\mathbb{C}), \text{tr}_{d_n})$ for the vector x_n . The commutator hypothesis says each $\text{Ad } U_n(\iota(s'))$ almost fixes ξ_n , so the residual $\xi_n - H_n \xi_n$ is Hilbert–Schmidt null. A Cauchy–Schwarz energy estimate then bounds the mass of $(1 - P_n) \xi_n$ by the residual and the uniform bound on $\|x_n\|$. Hence ξ_n is asymptotically concentrated in $\text{ran } P_n$.

Reversing the one-sided projection estimate. Put $T_n = \text{Ad } U_n(s)$ and $Q_n = T_n P_n T_n^*$, a projection of the same rank as P_n . The conjugation relation enters exactly once: for $\gamma \in \Gamma$ the element s^{-1} pulls the almost-fixedness of a vector of $\text{ran } P_n$ under $\iota(\Gamma) \supseteq s\iota(\Gamma)s^{-1}$ back to almost-fixedness under each $\iota(s')$, $s' \in S$. By the concentration estimate, the pulled-back vector is again almost in the subspace. Thus $\text{ran } P_n$ is almost contained in its conjugate, $\|(1 - Q_n) P_n\| \rightarrow 0$ — the finite-stage form of the one-sided inclusion $P \leq V P V^*$. Since $\text{rank } P_n = \text{rank } Q_n$, the equal-rank reversal estimate — for projections p, q of equal finite rank, $\|(1 - q)p\| \leq \varepsilon < 1$ implies $\|(1 - p)q\| \leq \varepsilon/\sqrt{1 - \varepsilon^2}$ — reverses the containment:

$$\boxed{\|(1 - P_n) Q_n\| \rightarrow 0.}$$

This is the middle implication of the display at the head of Section 3, and it is the finite-dimensional substitute for finiteness of a norm ultraproduct: a one-sided compression cannot enlarge the subspace.

Combining the estimates. Fix γ and $\varepsilon > 0$, let $M \geq 1$ bound $\|x_n\|$, and put $q = \min(1, \varepsilon/(40(M^2 + 1)))$. For all large n the three estimates hold at

tolerance q :

$$\|(1 - P_n)\xi_n\|_2^2 \leq q, \quad \|(1 - P_n)Q_n\| \leq q, \quad \|(A_n - 1)P_n\| \leq q,$$

where $A_n = \text{Ad } U_n(\iota(\gamma))$. Decompose the transported vector along P_n and Q_n :

$$T_n \xi_n = P_n Q_n T_n \xi_n + (1 - P_n) Q_n T_n \xi_n + (1 - Q_n) T_n \xi_n.$$

Since $Q_n = T_n P_n T_n^*$ and T_n is conjugation by a unitary,

$$\|(1 - Q_n)T_n \xi_n\|_2 = \|T_n(1 - P_n)\xi_n\|_2 = \|(1 - P_n)\xi_n\|_2 \leq q^{1/2};$$

the middle term obeys $\|(1 - P_n)Q_n T_n \xi_n\|_2 \leq \|(1 - P_n)Q_n\| \|\xi_n\|_2 \leq qM$, and the displacement estimate moves the first term by at most $q \|\xi_n\|_2 \leq qM$. Applying $A_n - 1$, whose operator norm is at most 2, to the last two terms and using the displacement bound on the first gives

$$\|(A_n - 1)T_n \xi_n\|_2^2 \leq (qM + 2qM + 2q^{1/2})^2 \leq 18q^2 M^2 + 16q \leq \varepsilon.$$

Since $T_n \xi_n$ is the vector of $U_n(s)x_n U_n(s)^*$, this proves the asserted convergence — with an explicit rate in terms of κ , $|S|$, M , and the multiplicative defects of U_n on the finitely many group elements involved. $\square$

C THE MAXIMAL GROUP C^* -ALGEBRA

This appendix records the maximal group C^* -algebra in the universe-relative form used by the formal development, whose type-theoretic foundations require it. The result is the usual maximal group C^* -algebra. Fix a set-theoretic universe $\mathfrak{U}$. For a $\mathfrak{U}$ -small group H , define $C_{\max, \mathfrak{U}}^*(H)$ to be the closed $*$ -subalgebra generated by the diagonal copy of H in the bounded product of all its nontrivial unitary representations on $\mathfrak{U}$ -small unital C^* -algebras. This algebra lives in the next universe. We suppress the subscript $\mathfrak{U}$ and write u_h for the canonical unitary associated with $h \in H$.

Proposition C.1 (universe-relative maximal group algebra). *The canonical map $h \mapsto u_h$ is injective. For every $\mathfrak{U}$ -small unital C^* -algebra B and every homomorphism $\rho: H \rightarrow \mathcal{U}(B)$, there is a unique unital $*$ -homomorphism $C_{\max, \mathfrak{U}}^*(H) \rightarrow B$ mapping u_h to $\rho(h)$ for every $h \in H$.* [Lean: GroupApproximation.manuscriptUniverseRelativeMaximalGroupCStar]

For a nontrivial target, projection to its coordinate gives the extension; for a trivial target, the map is unique. Density of the generated $*$ -subalgebra gives uniqueness, while the left-regular coordinate proves injectivity.

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